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Adjunct Lecturer K's 007 Briefcase

A Collection of Short Stories

Adjunct Lecturer K's 007 Briefcase

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A Sunday That Was Only Afternoon

The autumn rains were ending. We had just made love and were lying in bed, catching our breath, listening to the rain thin out. Raindrops fell on the outdoor unit of the air conditioner. “Whenever I hear that sound, I think of kalguksu,” my wife said. “Why?” I asked. “When raindrops fell on the tin roof, my mother boiled noodles. Then we sat around on the wooden porch and ate kalguksu. When she put shredded zucchini into clam broth, it was unbelievably good.” “My mother made pajeon. When she heard rain, she washed scallions, mixed flour with water, and made batter. Sometimes she told my older sister to go to the market and buy clam meat. My sister hated errands. So in the end I was the one who went to buy it. That really is an old story.” My wife made a gesture asking for my arm as a pillow. I stretched out my left arm. She rested her face on it and stroked my chest. I love this soft touch of my wife’s hand. “Shall we go out and eat kalguksu?” I asked. “Yes. But let’s lie here a little longer.” I looked quietly at the ceiling. I tried to think of other sounds that bring food to mind. But I could not quite come up with any. Maybe it was because of the hangover. My wife and I do not usually drink much, but yesterday we drank too much. Half a bottle of tequila and two bottles of wine, so we were both quite drunk. Yesterday was not any special anniversary. A few days earlier, my wife had told me about her first love. She said the man’s name was Maeng Yo-cheol. I teased her, saying his father must have been an amusing man to

put the characters for concave and convex into his son's name. My wife gave me a look and said she did not know what character the "yo" was, but the "cheol" was the character for brightness, or wisdom. Holding back my laughter, I said that if we did it right, we could probably find him even now. My wife did not answer. Then she told me the story of her first love, from the third year of middle school, that old time more than twenty years ago. The setting of her first love was, naturally, Yeosu, my wife's hometown. Her house was near Yeosu Jungang Market. At the time, my wife's family was neither especially well-off nor poor, but they had a couple of spare rooms and rented them out. I suppose it was probably a way for my mother-in-law to make some spending money. Usually men who worked on boats used the rooms for fifteen days or a month, but that summer a university student from Seoul rented one of the rooms for two months. He was my wife's first love, Mr. Maeng Yo-cheol. Of course, she said, it wasn't love at first sight or anything like that. Still, since a student was staying in the rented room, my mother-in-law must have paid some attention to him. So if she boiled noodles at lunchtime, she would have put some in a bowl and told my wife to take it to the low wooden veranda of the room where the university student was staying. Or in the evening, she would have told her to call him in for dinner. In those days, that sort of thing was natural, so there was nothing very strange about it.

My wife did not call the university student oppa. She called him Yo-cheol ajusshi. If it had been me, I would have been rather disappointed, but Yo-cheol ajusshi did not seem to mind. In any case, once Yo-cheol ajusshi took my wife to the beach in Yeosu and bought her sea cucumber and sea squirt, and she says she still cannot forget the taste. Is that true? I thought perhaps sea cucumber and sea

squirt were all wild then, so they must have been clearly different from the farmed ones we eat now. Besides, when it comes to taste, everyone has one memory or another they cannot forget. During the day, Yo-cheol ajusshi spent time by the sea with a fishing rod. At night, he read until late or played the harmonica. According to my wife, the sound of the harmonica was so mournful that my father-in-law would say, "Play one more tune." I almost forgot the watermelon story. One evening, Yo-cheol ajusshi came home and gave my mother-in-law a whole watermelon. Maybe he felt bad about eating dinner there all the time, so he had bought a large watermelon. They sat around the wooden platform in the yard and ate watermelon, and when my father-in-law asked why he had come down to Yeosu, he only answered that he had come to rest. That night, my wife imagined that Yo-cheol ajusshi had been heartbroken in Seoul and had come down to Yeosu to get over the sorrow. And she was swept up in a strange feeling, both hating and being grateful to the woman who had hurt Yo-cheol ajusshi's heart. Wasn't that exactly the sort of feeling a girl in the third year of middle school might have? At that part of the story, I loved my wife very much.

Toward the end of summer vacation, a big typhoon came. The wind blew fiercely, and the rain fell so hard that an umbrella was no use. Worried about Yo-cheol ajusshi, who had gone fishing, my wife took an umbrella and went out looking for him. She was badly scolded by my mother-in-law later, but what was a typhoon to a sixteen-year-old girl in love? When my wife reached the place where Yo-cheol ajusshi fished, he was already gone, and entry had been blocked. My wife came home in the rain, sniffing and crying. She was sick with worry over Yo-cheol ajusshi, but toward sunset he returned as if nothing had happened, wearing a white

raincoat. She felt so hurt by him that tears welled up in her eyes. When my wife told me this part, I could not help saying one thing. “Now I’m jealous.” My wife said that because Yo-cheol ajusshi had come back safely, she forgave everything. But then he quietly called her over and handed her a yellow raincoat. A small, cute yellow raincoat with a hood. Imagine it. How happy must she have been? Enough to make me jealous. Anyway, the adolescent girl cherished that raincoat and wore it whenever it rained. On the last day of the typhoon, Yo-cheol ajusshi hurried back to Seoul. He did not say what the reason was. He packed his things, said a simple goodbye, and left in a hurry. The yellow raincoat was torn during the next typhoon. My wife’s younger sister secretly wore it out and came back with it ripped here and there. Only then did I understand what the story of the yellow raincoat was, the one my wife and her sister sometimes talked about. My sister-in-law was scolded badly by my wife. She had been in the fifth grade of elementary school then, so she could not have known what story was attached to that yellow raincoat. But the girl in the third year of middle school held the torn yellow raincoat and wet it with tears all night. Yo-cheol ajusshi never contacted her after that. When I had heard the whole story of my wife’s first love, like a brief summer shower, I asked again. “Shall I find Yo-cheol ajusshi for you?” My wife quietly nodded.

Finding Mr. Maeng Yo-cheol was not difficult. I went on the internet and in thirty minutes found his phone number and even his address. How many people in the Republic of Korea could have the surname Maeng and the given name Yo-cheol? This sort of thing is nothing to me. When I handed my wife Mr. Maeng Yo-cheol’s phone number, she asked me to call him for her. I called him. And when he answered, I briefly introduced myself and passed the receiver to my wife.

In a trembling voice, my wife said into the receiver, “Hello. This is Park Jeong-hwa, the girl from the seaside in Yeosu. I wonder if you remember me.” Park Jeong-hwa, the girl from the seaside. Holding back the laughter that was about to burst out, I quietly went into the small room. My wife spoke with Yo-cheol ajusshi for about ten minutes. Then she hung up and came to me and said this. “He’s married. He has children. He lives in Seosan.” I held my wife. Surely, if Mr. Yo-cheol had been unmarried, she wouldn’t have left me for him, would she? I patted my wife on the back. That evening we drank tequila and wine and talked a lot about old memories. My memory is hazy because I was drunk, but I think my wife said that when blue crab season came, we should go to Seosan once.

“Shall we go eat kalguksu now?” my wife says. “Yes. And pajeon,” I answer quietly. My wife gets out of bed and goes into the bathroom to shower. The sound of cool water reaches the bed. I think. Where might dear Hee-jeong be now, and what might she be doing?

Sunday afternoon sunlight comes into the bedroom. I get up and go into the bathroom.

Marijuana

Jay and I are sitting in a bar somewhere in The Hague, drinking beer. Ever since we arrived in Amsterdam yesterday, Jay has been pestering me about wanting to try marijuana, just one joint, just once. It is not as though I am not curious myself. To be honest, I simply do not have the nerve. Not that I am a coward or anything. What scares me is not some textbook issue like marijuana being illegal in Korea, or Korean law applying to Koreans even overseas. Whatever anyone says, marijuana is a drug. That is the problem. I am the kind of person who gets hooked easily on things that are bad for him. I know perfectly well that once I fall into something, I have a hard time crawling back out. There are already too many things I started with a casual "What the hell, I'll try it once," only to find I could not quit. My life is already that of a washout pushed right to the edge of a cliff. I am in no position to add "drug addict" to the list.

Jay had recently come out of a long, exhausting divorce battle. At first she had planned on a divorce by mutual consent, but the division of property turned the whole thing into litigation, and only at the very end did she somehow manage to reach a settlement. Jay's hope that she and her husband might remain good friends after the divorce was smashed to pieces. She should never have entertained such a hope in the first place. If it had simply been another woman, perhaps it might not have gone as far as divorce. If he had not set up house with some young bitch, she

might have been broad-minded enough to let it slide, saying, “Men do that sort of thing.” In fact, Jay’s husband was not exactly innocent when it came to women. Whenever he came back from a round of golf with his high school friends, Jay could smell something strange on him. At first she thought it was just the cheap lotion and aftershave from the golf club locker room. But that was not it. One day, because the housekeeper’s father had died and the laundry had piled up for several days, Jay was sorting the clothes to run the washing machine when she happened to find a long blond hair stuck to her husband’s underwear. That night, after a terrific fight with him, Jay called me. And this is what she said.

“Careless bastard. Why the hell did he have to get caught with that?”

With Jay’s temperament, once suspicion took root, she could no longer believe anything. Whenever her husband came home after drinking, she checked his underwear. If he resisted and refused to take it off, she would go at him: “You bastard, where were you, and who were you screwing?” Then she picked up the phone, threatening to tell his family. Each time, her husband dropped to his knees and begged and begged with both hands clasped.

The incident that finally made Jay decide on divorce was her husband’s hidden camera. Last winter, Jay called and poured it all out.

“That crazy bastard filmed everything he did with me. And he has footage of himself doing it with other bitches too.”

Every night, whenever her husband went into his study, he locked the door behind him, and that had bothered her. So one day she searched his computer from top to bottom. She found nothing on the computer. Knowing how meticulous her husband was, Jay went through the books in the study one by one, and found a

small laptop hidden away. At first she gave a little laugh, thinking, “So the man’s been sneaking porn every night?” But that was not it.

“Are you going to get divorced?”

“Yeah… No, I don’t know. What should I do? I guess I have to, don’t I?”

Jay was clumsy about many things. Sometimes she was brisk and sharp, and sometimes she was plain stupid. Once she decided to ask for a divorce, her daughter became the biggest headache. Jay did not have the ability to raise the child, and even if she had, she had no intention of doing so. The girl had always been on her father’s side.

“Worry about that later. First, make copies.”

“How do I do that?”

“You don’t know? Then bring the laptop to my coffee shop right now.”

“Why there?”

“You said you don’t know how to copy files. Stop wasting time and come now.”

I swore to Jay on the life of Mong, my family’s dog, that I would never, under any circumstances, watch the videos I had backed up. Strangely enough, I do not trust myself, my wife does not trust me, and even my parents do not trust me, yet Jay has always believed me. I will say nothing about the unspeakable abuse that passed between Jay and her husband that night, the laptop smashed to pieces with a golf club, the neighbors calling the police, or the fight they had in front of the officers who showed up. The important thing is that because of the videos I had backed up, Jay’s in-laws had no choice in the end but to settle. Better a settlement than prison, wouldn’t you say?

Knowing perfectly well that her in-laws would not give up the child, Jay pressed even harder for custody. In exchange for letting her husband take the girl, Jay walked away with a fat settlement. She got a spacious apartment in Gimpo New Town and a four-story commercial building. Everyone around her said she had struck gold and envied her, but I saw it differently. To me, Jay looked as if she had been banished to some place of exile and left there to serve her sentence. Once, drunk, Jay said, "Maybe it's for the best. I don't have any regrets now. You have no idea how freeing it is to come home and find no one there." I thought that was not sincerity but bluff. When Jay drank, she spoke before thinking. After she sobered up, she did not remember what she had said. No, she did not even try to remember. Of course, she had not always been that way. If anything, I was the one who had been like that.

In fact, my own marriage is one step away from ruin. Of course, not because of Jay. My wife has no real interest in my relationship with Jay. She probably thinks, "Hmph. You? Please." If it is not a woman problem, what else could it be? In my case, as in most cases, it is money. My wife demanded a divorce, saying she could no longer stand watching me fail at everything I did. Karaoke room, Korean-style PC café, coffee shop—nothing I touched amounted to much. At least with the café I managed to recover part of the premium and unload it on some innocent woman; otherwise I really might have been wiped out. It would be nice if I could get a job, but there was nowhere for me to go. I thought about working the night shift at a convenience store, but with my stamina and all that, I gave up. That was something to consider only in the absolute worst case. Things had not fallen that far yet.

And more than anything, I did not want to leave my wife. When my wife brought up divorce, I begged her to try living apart for exactly three months, and if her mind still had not changed after that, I would step aside without fuss. In the end, she agreed. The only remaining question was who would live outside the home. My wife said she would stay with her parents. I begged her once more, please not to tell her family about our separation. Then my wife said, “You’ve cut ties with your own family, so you have nowhere to go, do you?” I insisted that since the apartment was in her name, it was only right for me to leave. Then I hurriedly packed and came outside. My luggage consisted of toiletries and a few pairs of underwear. I smoked a cigarette at the entrance to the apartment building. Somehow I felt as if I had walked straight into my wife’s strategy. It felt as though I had taken a counterpunch while standing there completely unguarded, having made no preparations for this sort of situation. From now on, I told myself, I would have to move more carefully.

After finishing one cigarette, I put another between my lips and called Jay. I will not lie. To be honest, since Jay owed me one, I was thinking of living off her for three months. Spending three months in hotels was out of the question with the money in my wallet. But I could not stay in a cheap motel either. Better to sleep rough than in a motel. Dirty sheets, moaning from the next room, the fan of a cheap refrigerator humming away, neon signs from the entertainment district, drunks shouting outside—just thinking about it was enough to make me shudder.

“Take a taxi and come right now.”

“Really?”

“Hey, what’s wrong with your voice?”

“Cigarette smoke must have gotten in my eyes.”

“What about taxi fare?”

“I still have the emergency money I tucked away when I closed the café.”

From the very first day of my separation, for two full months, I lived in a room at Jay's place. No matter how much Jay owed me, I could not eat and sleep there for free. So I thought I ought to at least earn my meals. As soon as I woke up in the morning, I went grocery shopping. Then I prepared two slices of toast, one boiled egg, half an apple, a quarter of a bell pepper, and morning coffee before waking Jay. Jay said she could not remember the last time she had eaten breakfast, and tears welled up in her eyes. Our breakfasts became routine. I also took charge of washing the dishes and cleaning the house. Of course, I had help from the dishwasher and the robot vacuum cleaner. Jay said we should each do our own laundry, but I said what did it matter when we were family living under the same roof, and I ran the washing machine once a week. Then one day it suddenly occurred to me: why had I never done any of this in my own home? When my wife kept asking me to help with the housework, why had I always dodged her and pretended not to hear? I could not understand it at all. With a dishwasher and a robot vacuum cleaner, it was not hard in the slightest. I wanted to call my wife and tell her that from now on I would take care of all the housework. Then perhaps my wife would calm down and ask me to come home. But it seemed my wife had other ideas. She did not want to see me changed. Instead, she said she had prepared the papers and told me not to come home but to meet her at a café near the apartment. Truly, I did not want even to dream of divorce or a divorce lawsuit like Jay's. Because I still loved my wife.

I did not go to the café. My wife called and tore into me. Then we made another appointment, and I did not go to that one either. I ran away from my wife. It may

look somewhat irresponsible, but I could not think of a better way. The night I missed the second appointment, Jay and I were watching a travel program about Europe on television when she said she wanted to see Paris once before she died. I said, full of bravado, "Then come with me." I was a little drunk at the time. Jay was fairly drunk too. The next day, when I said perhaps now was not the best time and that we should definitely go to Paris together another time, Jay insisted that absolutely would not do, and if I was going to say that, I should leave her house at once. In the end, I had no choice but to lose to Jay. For the time being, I decided to think about the divorce problem after the trip to Europe. Why drag around some useless worry when I had a major undertaking ahead? Perhaps because it was the off-season, two tickets to Paris were easy to get. As for lodging, once we arrived in Paris, we decided to take any hotel near the opera house. As soon as the tickets were booked, Jay went out shopping, saying she needed clothes to wear in Europe.

As we were going through departure procedures at Incheon Airport, my wife called. I did not answer. While I was buying cigarettes at the duty-free shop, the phone rang again, and again I did not answer. Then I turned the phone off. My wife must have been furious. All through our marriage, she had snapped at me countless times, saying she could not stand that kind of attitude of mine. But from my point of view, what could I have said to her? That because I could not divorce her, I was running away to Paris with a female friend? She would have called me insane, obviously. But if anyone knew my circumstances, no one could blame me. First, my wife had agreed to three months of separation and then tried to shove divorce papers at me after only two months. That was a clear breach of contract. Second, during the two months I was living outside the home, my wife did not once call first

to ask how I was. No matter how much she hated me, that was no way to treat her precious husband. Third—and I really do not want to bring this up because it has to do with Jay's privacy, but I suppose I have no choice—in those two months, Jay and I did not have sex even once. Of course, we had never done so before either. To be more precise, I had never once so much as held Jay's wrist. We were truly nothing more than pure friends. Platonic love, I mean—the sort of thing vulgar people in this world could never understand. Just those three points alone show that I am not such a bad guy. Then again, who isn't guilty of something? Even the fact that I did not pick up the phone at the airport was, in the end, my wife's own doing. All at once I felt strangely relieved. I wanted to get to Paris as soon as possible.

I had been to Paris once before. Back in college, like everyone else, I had spent about two weeks going around Europe—Paris, London, Rome, places like that. Of course I had not traveled alone. Naturally, I had gone on a package tour. Then as now, going abroad alone did not appeal to me. What was I supposed to do in a place where I did not speak the language if I sprained my ankle or got a stomachache? Go to a hospital? Fine. Let us say a hospital could solve that. But what if I had all my money stolen by a pickpocket on the subway in Rome, or ran into a mugger in some back alley in Paris? I really do not even want to imagine it. People may curse me, saying what kind of man has so little guts. That is all right. That is simply the kind of man I am. It is not pickpockets or muggers I am afraid of. It is the annoying mess that would follow. I cannot stand troublesome things.

It was not as if Jay and I had come to Paris with some grand travel plan. Like everyone else, we went up the Eiffel Tower, looked at the Arc de Triomphe, and walked along the Champs-Élysées. We stopped at a few cathedrals listed in the

travel book. No matter how many cathedrals you look at, a cathedral is still just a cathedral. Just as no matter how handsome a Korean temple may be, it is still a temple. We drank strong espresso at sidewalk cafés and smoked cigarettes in style. When we got hungry on our walks, we went into nice bakeries and ate our fill of fragrant French bread. Once I bought a pastry thinking it was filled with sweet red bean paste, only to discover it was packed with chocolate, which put me in a bad mood for a while, but for the most part the days were pleasant. In Paris, life became active. We walked and walked every day. I had been sitting still for too long. Perhaps it was because we had managed well enough on my wife's income alone. If I had held down a regular job like other people, perhaps things would not have come to this. I have the perfectly ordinary constitution of a man whose body instinctively rejects the word "workplace." Unfortunately, I have neither business sense nor business skill, so there is nothing else for me to do. When my wife said that doing nothing would be the best help I could give, perhaps she was not entirely wrong. To be honest, I have no desire to blame others, but the fact that I ended up like this is certainly not my fault alone. I suppose I simply had bad luck.

It is true that I have done plenty of things worth being criticized for, but one must not overlook the fact that I started them with good intentions. Take the café, for instance. At first business was good. But who could have known that within a few months every first floor of every building would have a café in it? When big corporate franchises too numerous to memorize came charging in as if their lives depended on it, what was I supposed to do? Retirees were pouring in their severance pay, even their entire savings. How could a decent person like me, someone who had hoped to run a refined little business listening to music and

drinking coffee at leisure, compete with that? If I had known things would go that way, I would never have started. It was lucky enough that I did not take a huge loss. As soon as I closed the café, my wife brought up divorce. Our relationship—neither marriage nor separation nor divorce—was already rushing toward disaster. If my wife had another man, I might have felt more at ease, but that was not the case either. If that man could have made her happy, I might easily have agreed to divorce. Love, too, once the foam has gone flat, is not much different from stale beer. When you meet dressed nicely, with makeup on and good clothes, everything is lovely; but once you get married and step into daily life, even good feelings are bound to go dull. Why else would people divorce over the cap of a toothpaste tube?

My wife must know. She must know there is no one on this earth who loves her more than I do. Still, it is not as if I had no complaints about her at all. I cannot stand the way my wife raises her little finger when she holds a pen. Even when she picks up a teacup, she always sticks out that little finger. In the old days, I found it cute and lovable. Now, whenever I see that little finger, I feel I might go mad. Just as there is no reason for liking someone, there does not have to be any reason for disliking someone either. In any case, not one thing in my life has ever gone the way I wanted. Again, I suppose I simply had bad luck.

The trip to Paris with Jay was smooth in every respect. If there was one problem, it was the sleeping arrangement. The fairly nice hotels near the opera house had no rooms. Chinese tour groups were to blame. At a hotel across from the Louvre Museum, there happened to be exactly one vacant room left, but unfortunately it was not a twin. We had to decide whether to find lodging on the outskirts of the city or sleep in the same bed. When I asked Jay whether it might be better to find a

guesthouse or a hostel, Jay folded her arms and stared at me for a moment as if putting me on trial. Feeling awkward, I muttered, "I mean, why are there so many people traveling around leisurely in the off-season?"

In the end, in Paris, I slept in the bed and Jay slept on the carpet with a blanket spread out beneath her. Since childhood, I have had the habit of not being able to sleep a wink unless I am in a bed, so I felt bad for Jay, but there was nothing I could do. I told her several times that we should move to a hotel on the outskirts, but Jay would not listen. She said she was fine sleeping below the bed, so what else could I do? I went along with it. Perhaps Jay was secretly hoping I would tell her to sleep beside me. But that would not do. I do not love Jay enough to sleep in the same bed with her. She is merely someone I have known since middle school, a longtime drinking companion and conversation partner. Jay probably thinks of me the same way. Now, if I say that, you must not conclude that Jay lacks feminine appeal. In fact, the opposite is true. If you do not look too closely, Jay could pass for a woman in her early thirties. There are hardly any wrinkles around her eyes or neck. Her skin is clean enough that you could search with your eyes washed out and not find a single skin tag. Sharing a bed does not necessarily make two people that sort of pair, but when I thought of my wife in Seoul, I simply could not. Later, if my wife asked what I had done with Jay in Paris, I wanted to answer proudly. I wanted to say that nothing at all had happened between Jay and me. How admirable would my wife find that? Just thinking about it made my heart swell.

Once I decided that Jay sleeping on the floor was all her own doing, I felt much lighter. Fortunately, there was no sleeping problem in Amsterdam. Here too every hotel was full because of Chinese tourists, but by luck we found a twin room whose

reservation had just been canceled. It was a splendid room, even with a terrace. I yielded the double bed to Jay and unpacked my things on the single bed. As a gentleman, I thought this much concession was only right. No matter how nice the room was, Amsterdam did not have much to see. The canals were boring, and the famous flower market only gave me a headache with all its flower smell. The Van Gogh Museum was so packed with Chinese tour groups that we could not see anything properly. Besides, I had not come all the way to Europe to look at paintings and such. The Anne Frank House was listed in the travel book as a required stop, but we did not go. I preferred simply walking wherever our feet took us and passing the time that way. Jay seemed to feel the same, because she did not suggest anywhere in particular. Then, in front of Descartes's house, which we discovered entirely by chance, I showed off a little to Jay, and that at least became a pleasant memory. It was from a documentary I had seen long ago on television, but according to it, Descartes had moved dozens of times and lived his whole life in hiding because of his dangerous writings. That house was probably one of his hideouts. I did not tell Jay that I had seen this on television.

After graduating from college, I once applied for a job at a major corporation and failed the entrance exam. One of the questions on that exam asked applicants to write down the titles of three major works by Kant. I wrote *Critique of Pure Reason* and *Critique of Practical Reason* in the blanks, but in the end I had to leave *Critique of Judgment* empty. Of course, I do not think that missing that one question is the reason I never became a department head or director at that major corporation. Still, I cannot say I feel no regret. If I had not missed that one question, who knows how my life might have unfolded? One never knows. In any case, when I told Jay

about it, she giggled and said, “And you were a philosophy major?” What is more, the incident is still handed down among my college friends like a legend. Even now, if someone says, “You know, that guy—Critique of Judgment,” people immediately think of me.

After loitering for a while in front of Descartes’s house, we turned back toward the hotel near Central Station. Then we took a wrong turn and found ourselves passing through the red-light district and past coffeeshops that sold marijuana. The street smelled acrid but oddly savory.

“This is marijuana smell, right?” Jay said.

“Probably. It definitely isn’t cigarette smoke. I heard you can smoke marijuana in coffeeshops in Amsterdam.”

“Should we try one too?”

“Are you crazy? Absolutely not.”

Perhaps because I cut her off so coldly, Jay did not bring up marijuana again. Since the weather was chilly, we stopped by the hotel, put on our coats, and went out to dinner. After Paris had spoiled my palate, Amsterdam did not seem to have much to eat. Everything was merely expensive. We finished a rough dinner and went into a bar for beer. I had not known the Dutch had so many kinds of beer. When Jay suggested we drink one glass of each kind, I agreed without hesitation. Around midnight, we staggered back to the hotel and fell into bed without even washing. The next morning, I barely managed to get up after ten. My head felt as if it would split open. After a hot shower and a shave, I felt somewhat better. When I came out of the bathroom, Jay was still asleep in bed. I called her name and shook her shoulder. There was no answer. When I shook her again, the thin strap of her

slip slid down from her shoulder. Then her nipple, small and erect, came into view from inside the slip. Without meaning to, I swallowed.

“Hey. Wake up already.”

Jay said her head hurt and told me to leave her alone a little longer. I gently covered her with the blanket so that her nipple would not show, and went down to the hotel lobby. Then I bought coffee and croissants at Central Station and returned to the hotel. Jay was in the shower. I left a note saying I would wait in the lobby and quietly came out of the room. While I sat on the sofa by the window in the hotel lobby waiting for Jay, a front-desk employee handed me a newspaper written in Japanese. I said I was not Japanese. Then he said something in Chinese. I said I was not Chinese but Korean. He looked embarrassed and apologized in English. Jay came walking down to the lobby. I handed her the coffee, now a little cooled.

“Where shall we go today?” I said.

“Anywhere but cheese or wooden shoes. Yesterday’s flower trip was a failure.”

“Then how about The Hague?”

“The Hague?”

“Yeah. The Hague.”

“The Hague of Yi Jun?”

“Yeah. That The Hague.”

“What’s there?” Jay said, opening her eyes wide.

“I don’t know. I just think maybe we ought to go once. You and I are Korean, after all.”

“Then let’s go.”

The Hague was less than an hour by train from Amsterdam Central Station. The city was astonishingly clean. It was completely different from Amsterdam, where the pungent smell of marijuana hung in the air. Jay and I went into a restaurant near The Hague Central Station, had a light lunch, and headed for the Yi Jun Peace Museum. It should have taken only ten minutes on foot from The Hague Central Station, but we lost our way and wandered for quite a while. On top of that, a sudden shower came pouring down from a perfectly good sky, so we had to buy a small folding umbrella. I said we should buy two, but Jay said we would only use them once and throw them away, so why waste money, and made me buy just one. To be honest, I was a little annoyed. Still, I did as Jay wanted. I was grateful that she had given me the bed in Paris. A small folding umbrella was not enough to stop the shower. Jay pressed her body against mine and linked her arm through mine, yet strangely enough only Jay's coat ended up soaked.

There was not a single tourist at the Yi Jun Peace Museum. Perhaps because the atmosphere was too solemn, our hearts grew heavy, and we came out after only ten minutes. Somehow I felt it was not the sort of place that suited us.

We walked through the streets of The Hague. The rain had eased, but the drops were still too thick to walk without an umbrella. The streets were quiet. Maybe because of the weather, even after walking for a long while, we hardly saw anyone.

"It would be nice to live somewhere like this," Jay said.

I said nothing. I felt sorry toward my wife. It was not because I had stolen a look at Jay's nipple that morning. Nor, of course, was it because I was now walking under one umbrella with Jay, her arm linked through mine. The reason I felt sorry toward my wife was that at Incheon Airport I had turned off my phone without

answering her call. In truth, that had bothered me throughout the trip. By now my wife's anger would have cooled quite a bit, but when we met, she would get angry again. I really did not want to see my wife angry. I did not want to hear her spit out crude words either. And more than anything, I could not bear the thought that my wife was suffering because of me.

Jay and I walked for a while without speaking. Jay too seemed lost in other thoughts, her face a little gloomy. Even the sky was dark and dingy, making the mood all the more melancholy.

"Shall we go somewhere and have a beer?" I said.

"At this hour?"

"With the weather like this, what's wrong with drinking a little early?"

"What time is the last train?"

"I don't know. But we should get back to Amsterdam before the last train stops running."

"Then shall we have just one quick glass?"

Jay and I went into a bar near The Hague Central Station. Though it was early for drinking, there were quite a few customers inside. We ordered two glasses of Dutch beer and sipped them.

"Do we have to go back to Seoul?" Jay said, rubbing the beer glass with both hands.

"Why?"

"I don't know. Just because."

"Then instead of going straight to London, shall we stop by Rome too? We could see Milan and Florence. We can change the plane tickets to another day."

“Should we? No. Let’s think about it a little more carefully. I want to get to London soon and see a musical too.”

“Sure. Then let’s take our time and think about it.”

“Maybe it’s for the best. I have no regrets now.”

“About what?”

“What do you think? The divorce. Now that I’ve split up, I had no idea I would feel this free.”

I could not believe Jay’s words. She was clearly lying. Her true feelings could not be like that. Perhaps I knew Jay better than my wife did.

“Why? Does it sound like a lie?”

“No. It’s not that.”

“I’m going to transform myself. When I get back to Seoul, I’ll start swimming again and go to the fitness club. It would be so nice if I could get rid of my cesarean scar. Mine is so big they say they can’t remove it completely.” Jay spoke with a serious expression. “Still, it’s all right. I’m still young, and I’m attractive enough. Aren’t I? I should meet a wonderful man too. I’ll love him, but I won’t marry him. I’m going to start singing again too. How wonderful would it be if I could stand on the stage at the Seoul Arts Center one more time?”

“But a little while ago you said you didn’t want to go back to Seoul.”

“When did I? I never said that. When I go back to Seoul, I’m going to love myself. More than anyone else.”

“Of course. You deserve to be loved. But shall we have another drink?”

“Good. But exactly one more.”

I ordered two more beers. And a little later, I ordered two more. I was getting drunk. I resolved that once I returned to Seoul, I would absolutely quit drinking. Of course, I would quit smoking too. I would show my wife that I was changing. My wife would like that side of me. No, perhaps she might even fall in love with me again. I was only in my forties. How was I supposed to live if my wife abandoned me? That would be no different from death. I would have to make that clear to my wife. To me, divorce was death itself. I ordered two more beers. I intended to quit drinking and smoking once I got back to Seoul, but not right now.

Two backpackers took seats at the next table. Every time they moved, a pungent marijuana smell drifted over.

“What do you think it feels like?” Jay said.

“What does what feel like? How am I supposed to know when you put it like that?”

“What do you think? Don’t you smell the marijuana? Every time those guys move, it smells like somebody farted after eating rotten mackerel.”

“What could be so special? It’s probably just a little stronger than cigarettes.”

“Can’t we try smoking just one joint?”

“No.”

“What do you mean no? Don’t they sell marijuana here?”

“They don’t sell marijuana in bars. Only in coffeeshops, apparently. If you drink and smoke marijuana on top of it, they say you get totally blasted.”

“Really? Let’s try just one. Really.”

“No.”

“You peeked at my breasts this morning, didn’t you? Did you think I wouldn’t know?”

“.....”

“When we get back to Seoul, I’m telling Mihyun everything.”

“.....”

“Ah, if I smoke just one joint, I might forget all about who peeked at my nipples.”

“Fine. Just one. That’s it.”

“Yeah. One is enough.”

“Then let’s go back to Amsterdam and smoke there. If something happens while we smoke here, it’ll be a nuisance. How about that?”

“If you break your promise, I’m telling Mihyun everything.”

“All right. So please stop bringing up Mihyun.”

We went straight to The Hague Central Station and got on a train bound for Amsterdam. As soon as we arrived at Amsterdam Central Station, we went into a coffeeshop near the hotel and took seats. The comfortable sofa and cozy atmosphere relaxed me. Jay’s face was flushed red, the beer from The Hague not yet fully out of her system. I gestured to the waiter. He came to our table and smiled at Jay and me. In clumsy English, I asked if we could buy marijuana. He spread a marijuana menu on the table and kindly explained the varieties and strengths. Among them, one called Krishna caught my eye. I assumed it was named after Krishna, the Indian god. When I asked for Krishna, the waiter said it was the strongest one and asked whether that was all right. I did not hesitate. It felt as though it had to be Krishna or nothing.

At the counter, a man who looked like the manager was changing the CD in the stereo. A quiet piano trio began flowing from the speakers. When the waiter put the marijuana on our table, Jay looked at me, beamed, and winked. I carefully rolled one joint. Then I rolled another. Jay rubbed her hands together and watched my movements with eyes full of curiosity. After I had rolled two large ones, I handed one to Jay. Jay wet her lips and put the joint in her mouth. When I lit it with the lighter, she inhaled deeply. I lit my own joint and took a drag.

“What kind of taste is this?” Jay said, coughing.

“All those stories about getting high on marijuana are lies. This is milder than a cigarette.”

“Ugh. We’ve been totally had.”

“Exactly. Why did you insist on smoking this expensive stuff? What a waste.”

“I’m sorry. I was being stubborn for no reason.”

We finished the joints in our hands. But even after smoking them all, nothing especially impressive happened. The marijuana had the musty smell of old hemp cloth. My mouth felt dry and grimy, so I kept sipping coffee the whole time.

“But listen, were we supposed to go to London the day after tomorrow, or Barcelona? No, was it Rome?” Jay said.

“Shall we go to London and see a musical?”

“A musical?”

“How about *The Phantom of the Opera* or *Les Misérables*?”

“Those are too gloomy. Isn’t there anything else?”

“Chicago or Mamma Mia?”

“Let’s do Mamma Mia.”

“Fine.”

“And what else?”

“I don’t know. We’ll see when we get there. But why is this music playing here?” I said, pointing at the speaker.

“What music?”

“You don’t know this song? It’s Lee Tae-won’s ‘Solgae.’ But it sounds a little strange. It must be the original recording. Wait.”

I closed my eyes and listened closely to the music coming from the speaker. It was definitely Lee Tae-won’s “Solgae.” I felt as if my body were floating into the air. It was an ecstatic sensation, as though I had become a black kite soaring through the sky. I hummed along to Lee Tae-won’s “Solgae” as it came from the speaker.

“Did you hear that?” I said.

“Hear what?”

“This song. It’s Lee Tae-won’s ‘Solgae.’ In the second verse of ‘Solgae,’ you know, ‘laughing at me’ was changed to ‘looking at me.’ In the third verse, ‘a meaningless day’ was changed to ‘a meaningful day.’ Back in the military-dictatorship days, those bastards censored the thing and changed the original lyrics however they pleased. Rotten bastards. Who would’ve thought I’d hear the original ‘Solgae’ in Amsterdam? Isn’t that strange? Maybe the manager here has some connection to Korea.”

“Hey, what is wrong with you?” Jay said, laughing.

“What did I do?”

“You idiot. This song is not Lee Tae-won’s ‘Solgae.’”

“Then what is it?”

“It’s Song Dae-kwan’s ‘Haetteul Nal,’ ‘The Day the Sun Rises.’ Listen properly.”

Then Jay suddenly stood up and began singing Song Dae-kwan’s “Haetteul Nal.”

“I came with a dream,

I came here,

sorrow and suffering, all of you, get out of the way,

nothing is impossible,

if you work hard,

bright and shining, the day the sun rises will come back,

bright and shining, the day the sun rises will come back.”

And sure enough, what was coming from the speaker was not Lee Tae-won’s “Solgae,” but Song Dae-kwan’s “Haetteul Nal.” The rhythm was so cheerful that even my shoulders began to bounce.

“Hey. Wait, wait a second,” I called to Jay.

“What?”

I grinned foolishly and said, “Let’s sing it together.”

Thoroughly stoned, Jay and I sang Song Dae-kwan’s “Haetteul Nal” at the tops of our voices. Jay even took the folding umbrella out of her bag, held it like a microphone, and imitated Song Dae-kwan. We faced each other and laughed loudly. Jay, laughing so innocently, looked beautiful to me. All the stress that had piled up inside me vanished like smoke. Then the waiter came over to our table and said we could not sing there. I took a deep breath and looked around. The people in the coffeeshop had even turned their chairs around and were giggling as they watched us. The young people smoking marijuana at a corner table were even clapping for us.

I grabbed Jay by the wrist and tried to make her sit down. Jay shook off my hand and shouted, "Why?" For a moment, I lost my words and stared at her. Jay must have sensed something was off too, because she looked around with cloudy eyes and then dropped into her seat.

"Ugh, how embarrassing," Jay said.

For a while neither of us spoke. No one was looking at us anymore.

"Shall we go?"

"Already?"

Jay put on a coy expression and stuck out her lips. Seeing Jay's cute lips made me remember the pink nipple I had stolen a glimpse of that morning. I pinched my earlobe hard.

"Let's smoke just one more. Roll one small one," Jay said.

"Let's stop now."

"What about what's left?"

"We'll throw it away."

"Why throw away something this expensive? Come on, can't we smoke just one more?" Jay said in a nasal, wheedling voice.

"Then let's go back to the hotel and smoke it there."

"But I want one more now. The memory of you peeking at my nipples still hasn't been wiped clean. Please, just one more."

I hesitated for a moment. Of course, it was not as though I had no desire to smoke one more myself.

"Our room has a balcony. If we smoke there, no one will know. That solves it."

“Fine. Then we’ll smoke the marijuana comfortably at the hotel. You promised. Definitely.”

“Fine, fine.”

Jay and I quietly sipped our coffee. Jay seemed to be thinking about something, drawing circles on the table with her finger.

“In middle school, you were shorter than me. Then you suddenly shot up when you got to high school.”

“Was I? I suppose maybe I was.”

“Do you remember the shepherd that used to live in our neighborhood when we were young? Sometimes it wandered around without even a leash.”

“The vicious shepherd from Principal Na Gyeong-su’s house? Of course I remember. It barked like a wolf every night. The son of that family had a temper every bit as nasty as that shepherd.”

“You remember. Once, on my way home from school, that shepherd charged at me, and you stood in front of me with that tiny body of yours and blocked the dog.”

“Did that happen?”

“When you shouted, ‘Go away! Go away!’ the shepherd got startled and backed off, flinching. If that dog had bitten me in the neck then, I would have died. You saved my life. You really don’t remember?”

“I don’t remember. Why?”

“Idiot. Never mind, then. The commercial building in Gimpo is a headache.”

“It’s brand-new. What headache?”

“Managing a building is no small thing. It would be nice if there were someone I could trust and leave it to.”

“Ask around. Or post a job ad on a recruitment site. That would be fastest.”

“When you get back to Seoul, are you really going to divorce Mihyun?”

“No. Why would I divorce her? I’m not going to.”

“The separation period is almost over now.”

“Even so, I can’t. Mihyun can’t live without me either.”

“That’s what you think, isn’t it?”

“No. Mihyun must think the same. We only needed some time apart to look at the situation calmly. When I go back, I’m going to quit drinking and quit smoking. If Mihyun sees that, she’ll definitely be glad.”

But I knew. I knew our marriage was already over.

Tonight, drunk on marijuana, Jay might seduce me. No, perhaps I might seduce Jay first. It is not as if I have no desire to kiss Jay’s cute lips and suck once on her pinkish nipple. But I will absolutely not have sex with Jay. If my wife learns that I did not sleep with Jay in Paris, or Amsterdam, or even London, perhaps she will think well of me. I have betrayed myself countless times, but I have never once betrayed my wife. I intend to stake my last hope on that.

On the way back to the hotel, I softly hummed “Solgae.”

“Can we not live without speaking? Like a black kite flying through the sky…”

It was past nine o’clock, but the sky was still bright. I knew perfectly well it was only the latitude.

The Basics of Logic

1

“Why do I not commit suicide?”

An unusual question appeared on the final exam for Logic. Professor An Ju-hee, who had tormented the philosophy freshmen all semester with truth functions, inductive reasoning, singular quantifiers and universal quantifiers, wrote only that one question on the blackboard and put down the chalk. The students' empty sighs and sighs of relief mixed together. Someone might have raised a hand and asked what logic had to do with suicide, but no one did. After glancing at one another, the students lowered their heads one by one and began writing their answers. A little while later, the professor quietly left the classroom.

When Professor An Ju-hee returned an hour later, I was the only one left in the room. She began reading the answer sheets the students had turned in. A smile spread across her lips. Outside the classroom, the history students were making a bit of noise. A few even opened the door, thinking the room was empty. The professor gathered the answer sheets and the attendance book from the lectern and said,

“Kim Shin. Time is up.”

I got up and handed in my answer sheet. The professor took it and looked at me gently.

“Philosophy is your minor, isn’t it? You said you were in French literature?”

Students who chose philosophy as a minor were rare. Perhaps because of that, the philosophy professors knew most of their faces. They also seemed to like the seriousness of minor students who had started philosophy late, more than that of students who had entered the department only because their scores had pushed them there.

“Yes.”

“Logic is a required course for majors, so turning in a blank answer sheet could become a problem.”

“Time will take care of it.”

The professor looked surprised.

“If you were going to turn in a blank sheet, why did you stay in the classroom by yourself?”

“I thought the answer sheets the other students had submitted shouldn’t get lost. If even I left, the history students in the hallway might come into the room and read them.”

“Do you have any exams left?”

“No. Logic is my last one.”

The classroom door opened, and a student who looked like the class representative politely asked us to vacate the room.

“Shall we go to my office for a moment?”

I glanced at my wristwatch.

“I don’t have much time.”

“Would enough time for a cup of tea be all right?”

“Yes. That much would be...”

We left the classroom and headed toward the faculty building. I walked slowly, a couple of steps behind Professor An Ju-hee. She stopped and waited for me to come up beside her. For a little while we walked side by side, but soon the distance opened again. I regretted not having made up an excuse about another appointment, and shortened my stride.

“Do you have any special plans for winter break?”

The professor said this as she handed me a mug.

“Shouldn’t I study logic again? If I fail again next year, my minor won’t be recognized.”

“You don’t have to worry about failing. It wasn’t a question with a right answer anyway. But why didn’t you write anything?”

“I thought no one had the right to know why I do not commit suicide. That is private.”

“I suppose I should apologize. I’m sorry.”

“You don’t need to.”

The professor rummaged through a drawer, looking for something.

“Would you like a cigarette?”

I held out my pack.

“Thank you. You may smoke if you want.”

I did not smoke. The professor opened the window a little. After finishing her cigarette, she took a book from the shelves and handed it to me.

“Would you like to read it?”

It was Camus’s *The Myth of Sisyphus*.

As I took the book, I unconsciously stole a glance at my wristwatch.

“Did you say you had an appointment?”

“No. It’s not that I have an appointment… Earlier, I only said I didn’t have much time because I thought you might give me an oral exam.”

When the professor smiled, I found myself smiling too.

“You have the kind of personality that doesn’t lie.”

She put a CD into the stereo. Perhaps because of the music, the awkwardness eased.

“Why did you put that kind of question on a logic exam?”

“It’s a question philosophy freshmen should think about at least once.

Wittgenstein is a representative logician who lived an illogical life. He was the heir to a wealthy family, but gave up his inheritance and taught children in a rural school. Can his life be explained with logical symbols? Whether some proposition is true or false is wordplay. The world isn’t the sort of place that can be determined by truth and falsity, is it?”

“I prefer Monk to Miles.”

I pointed at the cover of Miles’s *Prestige* album with the traffic light on it.

“Maybe because I’m a logician, I prefer something clear like Miles to music that is mysterious and foggy like Monk.”

The professor smoked another cigarette. The world around us was slowly getting dark.

“By the way, why did you choose philosophy as a minor when it doesn’t help you get a job?”

“Wouldn’t it help, rather? Philosophy is like music or painting. You can live without it, but once you come to know it, a different kind of world opens up.”

The professor looked at me with a warm smile. There was a knock, and a graduate assistant came into the room. I told the professor I should be going.

“I’ll be in my office every day during the break. If you come to campus, will you stop by from time to time?”

The assistant was staring at me. I hesitated for a moment.

“Yes. If I come to campus, I’ll come say hello.”

2

Winter. It rained more than it snowed. Blurred, blackish days continued. I studied at the university library every day, but I did not stop by Professor An Ju-hee’s office.

“I like you because you seem like an orphan.”

When Yeon-su said this in the classical music club room, I did not understand what she meant. I think I simply took it to mean that I looked lonely and desolate. Yeon-su was a philosophy student. Because of the stigma of having taken the entrance exam three times and because of her introverted personality, she had very few close people around her. She passed along small notices from the philosophy department to me, a French literature major back at school after completing

mandatory military service. And sometimes, when I was eating alone in the humanities cafeteria, she would quietly put a glass of water beside me and disappear. She enjoyed listening to Mozart and Chopin, and when I was alone in the club room I listened to Mahler's songs.

"An orphan? Everyone becomes an orphan someday. A person who never becomes an orphan commits the greatest unfilial act. Grandfather dies, father dies, son dies, grandson dies. That is the basis of filial order."

At my words, Yeon-su gave a small laugh. When Mozart's piano concerto ended, she said she had to go to her part-time job and left the club room. A little while later, some freshmen opened the club room door, each holding a CD in one hand. They hesitated, unsure whether to come in or not. I left the room.

The rain that had fallen steadily since morning turned to snow toward evening, and the bitter wind froze the road. What was I thinking? I turned my steps toward the faculty building. Before I knew it, I was knocking on the door of Professor An Ju-hee's office. There was no sign of anyone inside. After pulling hard once on my own ear, I walked toward the elevator. Just then the office door opened, and I heard Professor An Ju-hee's voice.

"Kim Shin?" When I turned my head, she said, "Who knocks only once? That isn't polite."

"I'm sorry. I thought I might be bothering you for no reason."

That mock-prim look of hers soon brightened.

"It's all right. Come in. Have a warm cup of tea before you go."

The office was thick with cigarette smoke.

"I really have to quit these damned cigarettes."

The professor opened the window a little.

“Coffee? Or...”

“Coffee would be good.”

I took a CD from my bag and handed it to her. She looked a little surprised.

“I thought this was the clearest of Monk’s albums.”

“All right. Thank you. Shall we listen to it now?”

“No. It will be better when you’re alone. Maybe because it’s a story about Monk himself, it doesn’t taste right when several people listen to it together. When I listen to Monk, the world becomes quiet.”

“Is that so? Then I’ll listen to it when I’m alone. But you seem to know a lot about jazz.”

“It just happened that way. When I was in the army, my mother and older brother died in a car accident, and my brother loved jazz. I decided to keep the LPs and CDs among his things. So naturally I came to listen to them.”

“I brought up something unnecessary. I’m sorry.”

“It’s all in the past. Maybe time eats up emotions too. Now I feel numb about it.”

The professor took out her cigarette pack. We smoked together.

“There was another philosophy freshman who turned in a blank answer sheet.”

“Lee Yeon-su?”

“Oh. How did you know?”

“I didn’t think there was any other freshman who would do that.”

“Your girlfriend, perhaps? I should have failed Lee Yeon-su.”

The professor laughed with a playful look.

“It isn’t anything serious. Maybe because I’m in French literature, she takes care of this and that for me.”

“I imagine you’re popular with the female juniors.”

I glanced at my wristwatch.

“Do you have an appointment?”

“I picked up the habit of checking my watch in the army, and it doesn’t go away. A few days ago I read one of Wittgenstein’s books.”

“Which one?”

“The *Tractatus Logico-Philosophicus*.”

“A troublesome book.”

“I was drawn to the parts about limits. The limits of language, the limits of the world, the limits of cognition. And the limits of life. I thought suicide, in the end, was also a problem of limits.”

A smile spread across the professor’s lips. Then she took up her desk calendar, checked her schedule, and said,

“Shall we have dinner together tonight? If you don’t have any special plans.”

Instead of having dinner, we drank beer and had light snacks, with philosophers as our side dishes. It began with Wittgenstein. When she talked about the Dictionary for Elementary School Students he had written based on his experience as a teacher, Professor An Ju-hee looked a little excited. She said the dictionary was not arranged alphabetically, but organized around words of the same kind, adding their derivatives, and that the structure was very Wittgenstein-like. But when she spoke of how he had eventually been forced to leave teaching because of an incident in which he struck a student’s palm, she let out a long sigh. The conversation then

naturally moved on to Klimt. By the time we were talking about Ravel's Concerto for the Left Hand, I was a little drunk. After that, I do not remember very well what we talked about. I only vaguely remember that the professor was speaking of the husband she had married during her studies abroad in the past tense.

The road, covered with a thin skin of ice, was very slippery.

"Where do you live?"

"Five minutes on foot."

"I'll walk you home."

"It's all right. Shin, you should go home too."

Because of the ice, the professor briefly lost her balance. I took her hand as she was about to fall.

"It's all right. I'll go by myself."

The professor closed the right hand I was holding. Then she gently slipped her fist out of my hand.

"You'll come to my office again, won't you?"

"Yes."

I kept watching until she had completely disappeared from view, worried that she might fall.

After drinking beer with Professor An Ju-hee, I began visiting her office once or twice a week. Sometimes she bought me lunch at the faculty cafeteria, and sometimes we talked about books she had lent me.

"I think I should have majored in metaphysics. When I was a student, I thought ontology was just talk in the clouds, so it didn't interest me. But the more I study, the more I think I understand why Aristotle called it first philosophy."

I smiled.

“Oh? Why?”

My face flushed, and I could not answer.

3

“Do you want to go see the sea tomorrow? The winter sea.”

Yeon-su said this cautiously in the club room on the day she finished her part-time job.

“The sea?”

“You don’t want to?”

“It’s not that.”

“Then it’s settled. I already bought two tickets yesterday. Gangneung is closer, but I still want to go to Sokcho. Sokcho has mountains, and a lake, and the sea.”

Recently Yeon-su had begun putting on clumsy makeup. Perhaps because of that, she looked more alive than when her face was bare.

“It will take five hours by express bus.”

“I already told my family I’m going on a club retreat.”

Yeon-su’s pink cheeks flushed red.

After Yeon-su left the club room for her last part-time shift, I went to Professor An Ju-hee’s office. The door was locked. I was about to leave a note in her mailbox on the first floor, saying I did not think I could keep our appointment tomorrow, when the professor entered the lobby of the faculty building.

“Shin is here. What are you doing down here? Let’s go up to my office.”

The professor took off her coat and hung it on the rack. Then she made coffee and emptied the ashtray.

“I wanted to ask if we could move tomorrow’s movie to next week.”

“Something urgent came up?”

“A friend suddenly asked me to go to Sokcho tomorrow. She even reserved the tickets without asking me, so I don’t think it’ll be easy to change the date. I’m sorry.”

“Yeon-su?”

The professor said this with a bright smile.

“You said it wasn’t serious, but now it looks like it might become serious.”

“It’s not that. I also wanted to see the winter sea.”

After returning from the trip to Sokcho with Yeon-su, I went to see the movie I had promised to see with Professor An Ju-hee. As we left the theater after the film ended, neither of us said anything. It was a film that made one side of my chest ache with cold sadness. For some reason, I felt uncomfortable looking straight at Professor An Ju-hee’s face. She must have felt awkward too, because she did not bring up the movie until we had coffee at a café and parted. That night Yeon-su called my house. She was not usually talkative, but that night she went on about small, trivial things in a strangely detailed way. Then, for a while, only her breathing came through the receiver.

“You went to see *Damage* today, didn’t you? Was it good?”

Yeon-su’s voice was trembling.

“It was a sad movie.”

“I’m going to see it with friends tomorrow.”

Only Yeon-su’s small breathing could be heard through the receiver. Suddenly, I felt boundless affection for her. It was as if an uncontrollable feeling of love were being tattooed deep inside my chest.

“Wait. I’ll come now.”

We made love that night. Yeon-su never once brought up Professor An Ju-hee. Even now, I do not know whether that was because she trusted me, or because of her pride. No useless rumor caused by Damage went around.

Along with the tuition bill for the new semester, a notice arrived at my house saying that I had been selected for a merit scholarship. Because of Logic, I had not expected a scholarship, but my grades in my major courses were unexpectedly good. Around that time, my visits to Professor An Ju-hee’s office also grew less frequent. We were both busy, and once the new semester began, her office was always crowded with philosophy students. So naturally we came to keep some distance. Besides, I gave up my philosophy minor. Instead, I took courses in physics and biology, and learned elementary Latin. In the evenings, I took conversation classes at the French Cultural Center. Time flowed indifferently.

When final exams ended and summer break began, I heard from Professor An Ju-hee. She said she had resigned from the university at the end of the semester. She was leaving for Boston at the end of July, and wanted to see me once before then.

“I’m sorry. The house is a mess because of the moving boxes.”

When twenty minutes had passed after our appointment time and she had still not come out, I called her. She said she could not leave because she was waiting for an important phone call. Instead, she asked me to come to her place for a little while.

We were exchanging news about each other when the phone rang. The professor began speaking in English. Then she made a gesture asking my pardon and went into a room. The call continued for quite a long time. I looked around the living room. The only appliance was a small stereo. There were many CDs. Thelonious Himself, the album I had given her the previous winter, was sitting on top of the stereo. There were no decorations on the walls. No family photograph, no ordinary painting. Judging by the absence of nail marks in the wall, it did not seem to be because of the move. The books were inside thick cardboard boxes, but the boxes had not yet been sealed with tape. There were more than thirty of them.

This time too, we drank beer instead of having a meal. Wittgenstein did not appear. I told her I had given up the philosophy minor. I also told her I had taken physics and Latin courses for a semester. We talked about the scene in Joyce's *A Portrait of the Artist as a Young Man* where the students are scolded for not knowing the Latin declension of mare. Beyond the pub window, a fine rain began to fall. I did not ask why she was resigning and leaving for America. I only realized that the paperwork with the husband from whom she had long been separated had been settled. The man who had existed only in the past tense seemed to have briefly leapt into the present, then been buried again in the past tense, becoming someone who would no longer exist in the future. The professor looked solitary. Not lonely, not merely desolate, but solitary. I felt that an old solitude, sunk deep into her bones, was lodged throughout her body. The raindrops grew heavier. The wind also began to blow hard. While we waited for the rain to thin out, we drank a few more glasses of beer, and the alcohol rose in us. As the time approached when the subway would stop running, we had no choice but to get up. The professor had no

umbrella. She was wearing jeans and sandals and said she would run home, but the rain was falling too hard for that. I opened my folding umbrella and walked her home. It was only a five-minute walk, but we were soaked through. Every time we took a step, her rain-soaked breast touched my right arm. The subway and buses had stopped running. Because of the downpour, I could not catch a taxi either. Hiding myself under the small folding umbrella, I walked and walked endlessly, thinking of the feel of that small breast against my right arm. It was a quiet night.

4

After graduation, I got a job at an affiliate of a large corporation. I was promoted a little faster than the other people who had joined the company with me, and the stress was just as great. When I felt I had settled into my position at work, I naturally married Yeon-su. Yeon-su wanted a child. I refused. I secretly marked her menstrual cycle in my diary, and during her ovulation period I even avoided drinking gatherings. If I had no choice but to attend a company dinner, I slept alone in the small room. My father-in-law said we should stop loving only each other like a pair of doves and now make a real family, but he did not force us. Yeon-su's family found me, a man of few words, difficult, and I was comfortable with that. My father never remarried and died in the end. His old age, after losing his beloved wife and eldest son in a single car accident, was lonely.

"I like you because you seem like an orphan."

I now understand the meaning of what Yeon-su said in the classical music club room. Nothing surrounding me bound her. Even before I met Yeon-su, I had been emotionally orphaned. We did not bind each other. As long as we did not cross the line, we lived our own lives independently. Sometimes Yeon-su's hair smelled of men's aftershave, but I pretended not to know. I did not want to disturb our comfort and peace with useless fantasies. Yeon-su must have thought the same way, because she paid no attention to lipstick marks on the collar of my dress shirts. She worked as an editor at a publishing house and made several bestsellers. When a marketing book she had edited was designated required reading at my company, I congratulated her, but I did not read the book. She too seemed to regard the bestsellers she had handled as nothing much. Yeon-su received job offers from several major publishers, but turned them down each time. She became the youngest team leader at the publishing house, and not long afterward was promoted to editor-in-chief. One day, when Yeon-su said she was going to have a sterilization procedure, I did not try to stop her. I no longer needed to mark her menstrual cycle in my diary. An apartment not too small for two people, two cars, and an audio system that did not discriminate between classical music and jazz. Yeon-su and I walked along the road set out for us in that way. Wittgenstein and Camus slowly faded from my memory as people whose names had not been spoken once in over ten years. I could still pronounce the name of the French cosmetics Yeon-su used, BEAU-TEMPS, correctly, but what it meant did not readily come to mind. At the company, French was a dead language, like Latin. Questions such as "Why do I not commit suicide?" had no room to enter our lives. As Professor An

Ju-hee had said, there was a time for such philosophical anguish. The world had settled into a murky dark gray, and nothing could be explained by logic.

My friendship with Professor An Ju-hee continued by email. She said she was teaching logic and philosophy of language at a university in Boston. Not long afterward, I heard that she had been appointed full professor. A few years ago, when I went to New York on a business trip, I tried to meet her. From New York to Boston was a stone's throw. But at that time she was in Seattle. I tried everything I could to extend my business trip by a few days, but it was no use. On the flight back to Seoul, I tossed and turned without rest. When I arrived at Incheon Airport, I did not go straight home. I called Yeon-su into the city, had a fine dinner with her at a hotel, and made fierce love to her. For a while, contact with Professor An Ju-hee was cut off. I sent emails, but she did not reply; she did not even open them. I tried calling, but she did not answer. I thought she must be absorbed in some other important work, or perhaps had fallen in love with a wonderful man, and I waited until she contacted me first.

"I'm here in Busan."

The voice on the other end of the phone trembled a little, but it was clearly Professor An Ju-hee.

"Yes."

"Shin is still a man of few words."

"Professor, are you well?"

I picked up my desk calendar and checked my schedule first. Yeon-su had left for New York on a business trip the day before and was not in Seoul.

“Of course. I’ve been teaching here since this fall semester. I’m late in getting in touch, aren’t I? I’m sorry.”

My throat closed with longing, and I could not say anything.

“I’d like to see Shin once…”

“Professor, I can see you this Saturday. I’ll call you when I arrive in Busan.”

We asked after each other once more and hung up. I left the office, abandoning the work that had piled up. And I walked and walked through the darkening streets until the streetlights came on.

5

“You haven’t changed at all, Shin.”

On Saturday morning, after taking half the clothes from my closet and putting them on and taking them off, I finally wore jeans, a slightly pink shirt, and a light jacket. When she saw me, the professor said this in surprise.

“You don’t have any belly at all. I’d believe it if someone said you were a college student. Now I’m jealous.”

For a moment she made that mock-prim expression of hers, then smiled brightly.

“You haven’t changed either, Professor.”

Professor An Ju-hee was beautiful, just as she had been long ago. Her open eyes, her warm smile, and her slender build. And perhaps because of her gray-streaked hair, she gave off an even more intellectual charm. My chest swelled. Whether because the longing I could not bear had exploded, or because I was relieved to

confirm that she was all right, I wrapped both arms tightly around her. She did not refuse, and held me too.

“I didn’t know Shin had this side to him.”

The professor said this as we left Busan Station. I answered by scratching my head.

Sitting by a window that looked out on the sea, we breathed life back into faded memories. Then the events of the past unfolded as clearly as if they had happened yesterday.

“Why did you give me a B back then? Do you know I nearly missed my scholarship?”

“Wasn’t it a C? A B was more than enough for a bad student who turned in a blank answer sheet. There were a few students who wrote serious answers. I probably gave those students A’s and the rest B’s.”

“I guess it wasn’t graded on a curve then.”

“Was it? I don’t remember that very well. But one parent protested fiercely, saying I was encouraging students to commit suicide. I had a hard time because of that. Since it was just before the new semester started, I don’t think it was about grades.”

“I wasn’t in the philosophy department, so I didn’t know that had happened. I’d given up the philosophy minor too, so I had no chance to meet philosophy students.”

“I think it was good that it happened then. At the time, I wasn’t ready to teach anyone. I thought maybe it was for the best.”

“Did you resign because of that?”

“No, not because of that. I wanted to study more. And luckily, a university in Boston was looking for someone like me. Family matters had been settled by then too. You know, don’t you?”

The professor spoke calmly, as if she were talking about someone else’s affairs.

“I noticed because you always spoke of him in the past tense.”

“Really? You have a good eye. To think you noticed all that.”

We talked on and on, losing track of time. She was pleased that I had become more talkative. I joked that perhaps it was because my male hormones had decreased. She made that mock-prim look of hers, then let a smile settle around her lips. For dinner, we moved to a raw fish restaurant with a view of the sea. Beyond the wide window, autumn rain began to fall steadily.

We spoke openly about the paths our lives had taken, fitting our times together. She was still single, and still studying in order to broaden her horizon as a philosopher. She said that although she taught philosophy to students at the university, she no longer asked questions such as “Why do I not commit suicide?” And she said that the year before, that is, during the period when we had lost touch for a while, she had undergone surgery for breast cancer. Looking back now, food that did not suit her, an irregular life, and a solitude worse than either had slowly eaten away at her health.

“Will you come up to Seoul?”

“I don’t know. It’s my first time in Busan, and I like that it has the sea.”

“There is still something of a girl in you.”

“A girl?”

The corners of her mouth lifted gently toward her ears, and a red glow rose in her cheeks. No longer drinking alcohol, the professor filled her glass with water and toasted me every time I raised my drink. It felt like making a new old friend. I was comfortable, but my heart stirred.

“I’ll walk you home.”

She quietly nodded.

“You live close to the sea.”

I said this when the taxi stopped at the entrance to her apartment complex. If it had not been raining, we would not have needed to take a taxi. I opened my folding umbrella.

“Could you hold the umbrella with your left hand?”

I moved the umbrella to my left hand. Then she stood on my left. Sharing the umbrella, we slowly walked into the complex toward her apartment. Every time we took a step, her breast brushed against my left arm.

“May I contact you again?”

“Of course. Anytime.”

She did not invite me inside. Thinking of the feel of that small breast against my left arm, I walked toward Haeundae Beach. The waves were calm.

Sometimes I created business trips to Busan. I exercised my authority within the bounds of not abusing my position. The employees at the Busan branch were tense each time the head of the audit department from headquarters came down. On Saturdays, I spent time with Professor An Ju-hee. We often walked along the beach together, and each time I usually had to listen to one of her philosophy lectures. She said she preferred the late Wittgenstein, who had simply told us to leave things to

nature, to the young Wittgenstein who had said we must remain silent about what cannot be spoken of. When she said this, she looked at ease. She was curious about my daily life too, but I avoided talking as much as possible about my dull and tedious company life. And when Yeon-su came up, I quietly turned the conversation elsewhere. Since I had not crossed the line I had to keep, I did not tell Yeon-su about my friendship with the professor. But our friendship did not last long. Less than two years after settling in Busan, Professor An Ju-hee's cancer returned, and she came to the end of her short life.

When death was near, I held the professor's hand for the first time. When I wrapped her right hand in both of mine, she smiled gently and interlaced her fingers with my left hand.

Hyung's Life

1

My hyung died.

Late one night, while I was at the office reviewing our division's marketing plan for the new year, the detective in charge called to tell me. I was not surprised. Everyone who had known my hyung, myself included, had assumed that he had died a long time ago—more than ten years ago, in fact.

“What was the cause of death? Was it suicide?”

My voice was trembling. The detective said he had suffocated when food became lodged in his airway.

“The body had been left undiscovered for a long time, so determining the cause of death was difficult, but there were no signs of suicide or homicide.”

“Left undiscovered?”

The detective said the body had been found a month after his death, after a neighbor reported it. A violent shiver ran through me. He asked whether I could come down to Cheonan the next day, and I said I could.

“How did you get my number?”

The detective said I was the only person listed in the deceased's phone. I could not understand it. My hyung. His life.

Jang Cheolsu was not my biological brother. We were maternal cousins. He was two years older than I was. He was born in a southern seaside city where the sea ended and the land began, but after my aunt and uncle divorced, he came to live with us when he was twelve, and we grew up together. There were somewhat complicated circumstances behind it. Neither of us knew the truth at the time. The adults kept it from us and said nothing. Even though they tried to keep it secret, as we grew older Cheolsu hyung and I came to understand the reason naturally. Adults often forget that children are always listening. No matter how quietly they whispered, I heard everything while pretending to sleep, pretending to play, pretending not to pay attention.

I kept it secret from Cheolsu hyung that he was not my uncle's biological son, but at some point he had figured it out too. At the time, I did not know that this was the reason my aunt and uncle had divorced. My ears may have been open, but I was still too young to know anything about the world. Cheolsu hyung may have known even that. Looking back, I think Cheolsu hyung had already finished growing up before he turned thirteen.

2

"Are you sure this is Jang Cheolsu?"

The detective in charge asked me.

“I don’t know.”

The face in the photograph he handed me was so badly decomposed that it was almost impossible to recognize. There was nothing that allowed me to connect the person in the photograph with the tall Cheolsu hyung I remembered, with his sharp eyes. The long hair and beard were part of it, but the man in the photograph looked too far removed from Cheolsu hyung, who had always kept himself neat. The detective handed me another photograph. Tears ran from my eyes. It was him. It was Cheolsu hyung’s foot. Three black moles beneath the ankle bone of his left foot, and his unusually long little toe. I could not stop crying. The detective stepped away for a while. Was it relief that the body of the hyung I had believed dead long ago had finally been found, so that I could give him a funeral? Or had something collapsed inside me—the small hope that somewhere, somehow, he was still living well? Tears ran down my cheeks.

The detective returned and handed me several documents, and I signed each one. He gathered the papers I would need for the funeral and the certificates required to register the death.

I left the police station and went to the hospital morgue where the body was being kept. I discussed the funeral arrangements with the morgue manager. I decided not to receive mourners and to have the cremation the next day. According to the manager, it had been years since they had seen a body in such an advanced state of decomposition. No one asked me what had happened to my hyung. I asked my hyung nothing either. I left the morgue and put on a black tie.

During the first year after Cheolsu hyung came to live with us, my aunt visited him about once every two months. Whenever he returned from an outing with her,

he would usually be wearing new clothes with a Nike or Adidas logo, or a new pair of sneakers. Strangely, once my aunt left, he never wore those clothes or shoes again. He would put them back in their paper bags and hide them deep in the wardrobe. I could not understand him. Once, I secretly wore Cheolsu hyung's Nike sneakers outside and got into terrible trouble. He searched the entire neighborhood for me, and the moment he found me, he shouted at me to take them off at once. He was usually quiet and mild, and the anger in his eyes frightened me so much that I took the shoes off right there. Without saying another word, he clutched them to his chest and disappeared. I walked home crying, with a shard of glass stuck in the sole of my foot, only to be scolded by my parents all over again. I felt so miserable that there was no one in the house on my side that I sniffled through the entire night, but neither my parents nor Cheolsu hyung paid any attention to me. For a while, I refused to speak to him or answer him when he spoke to me. He was exceptionally good at school. He did not merely come first in his class; after transferring to our school, he never once failed to rank first in the entire school. By comparison, I spent my time flipping through comic books and collecting baseball player cards, and at school I was an invisible boy with no presence at all. The few people who remembered me or knew who I was thought of me as something like Cheolsu hyung's idiot little brother. When Cheolsu hyung came to live with us, my comfort and peace disappeared. His very presence made me uneasy. That uneasy coexistence, which lasted more than three weeks, ended with the autumn rains the year my aunt came to see him for the last time. When Cheolsu hyung returned from an outing with her, there was a faint smile around his mouth as he held out a baseball glove to me. Even now, just thinking about that glove makes my heart beat

faster. It was a first baseman's mitt used by a professional baseball player. It was about a finger joint longer than the gloves used by infielders or outfielders. At the time, Cheolsu hyung had absolutely no interest in professional baseball. And yet he gave me a first baseman's mitt made of real leather, not synthetic leather. In return, I gave him the baseball card I treasured most, the one with a photograph of my favorite professional player. That was how we became friends.

3

I booked a room near the hospital and went into a restaurant for a late lunch, but I could not eat anything. The face and foot of Cheolsu hyung in those photographs kept appearing in my mind, and hunger vanished, replaced by nausea. My head felt empty. I could not bring myself to return to the room, so I walked through the unfamiliar city. Why had my hyung come down here, a place where he had no ties at all, and chosen to live here? The slip of paper with his address, which the detective had given me, grew damp with sweat inside my pocket. I thought about going to the place where he had lived, but somehow I did not want to. I needed time. A little time to accept his death. And the courage to face reality.

My aunt, who had visited Cheolsu hyung roughly once every two months, died in a traffic accident at the beginning of that winter. I secretly overheard the adults saying that she had been working in a drinking establishment to make a living, and that one night, drunk, she had crossed the road illegally in front of Yeongdeungpo Station and been hit by a taxi. At that age I did not understand what the word bar

meant, so it meant nothing to me. For Cheolsu hyung it was different. I think he was more shocked by the fact that my aunt had worked at a bar than by the fact that she was dead. And he hated all the relatives who had allowed her to end up working there. Cheolsu hyung did not cry at her funeral. My uncle was nowhere to be seen. When we returned home after the funeral, I secretly watched Cheolsu hyung cut apart the clothes and shoes with the Nike and Adidas logos. Tears were running from his eyes. He stopped speaking. It was not aphasia, but unless something absolutely had to be said, he almost never opened his mouth. He locked himself in his room all day and did nothing but study. He appeared only briefly for meals, then went straight back inside. My mother would sometimes hug him for no reason at all. Each time, he simply stood there with an expressionless face.

One day, my father took Cheolsu hyung to a cafe near our house. Childish as I was, I felt resentful toward my father. I wanted to go to a cafe too. There were pretty young women there, and somehow I imagined that if I went inside one, I would become an adult faster. I still do not know what my father and Cheolsu hyung talked about there. Strangely, though, after that night Cheolsu hyung began to speak again. He did not become the playful, smiling boy he had once been. But he smiled in front of people, and he said what needed to be said.

My father was a broad-minded man. Even in those days, when one group of people was devoted to changing the world and another group was determined to keep it from changing, my father never leaned too far in either direction. When I was in university, neglecting my studies, spending my time in clubs, and throwing myself into protests, my father told me that if I looked at the world only in black and white, everything became ridiculous. I understand what he meant now.

Suddenly I missed my father, who had died so many years ago. If he were alive now, I would not have had to bear my hyung's death alone like this.

I walked without direction, completely lost. Two girls walking ahead of me were laughing at a black plastic bag that seemed to be following them. Filled with wind and puffed up, the bag rolled along beside the girls. They walked with the black bag between them. When the traffic light changed, the girls crossed the street. The black plastic bag did not seem to know what to do. The wind had stopped.

4

There was no one in the twenty-five-seat minibus carrying my hyung's body except the driver and me. The crematorium workers and the driver helped carry the coffin. I tried to give them some money, but they refused, so I thanked them with some bottled drinks instead. People die on weekdays and weekends alike, so we had to wait more than three hours. The cremation began well after lunchtime. Only the crematorium workers showed proper respect to the dead. I had contacted our relatives, but no one came down. During the cremation, I sat in the waiting room. I had slept badly the night before and was exhausted. The youthful face of Cheolsu hyung in the funeral portrait—made by enlarging the photograph from his identification card—made my chest ache. I closed my eyes.

Cheolsu hyung dropped out of high school. Because of problems with drinking and smoking, my mother was called to the school almost every week. My father took him to a cafe several times to talk to him, but that method no longer worked.

Cheolsu hyung had entered high school ranked first in the school, but by the time he dropped out the following spring, his grades had fallen to the bottom. Drinking, smoking, grades—none of those were much of a problem compared with the fighting. He could not control his anger over even the smallest things, and whenever a quarrel started, he tried to settle it with his fists. If fists were not enough, he swung whatever he could get his hands on. The more opponents there were, the more violent he became. In the end, my father decided not to send him to school anymore, and Cheolsu hyung readily agreed. He no longer tormented my parents by running away from home or getting into violent trouble, but he shut himself in his room again. He killed time listening to loud music and reading strange books.

During that period, Cheolsu hyung and I hardly spoke. I was not afraid of him. What I could not stand was the way he made my parents suffer. But my parents told me that no matter what happened, I must never fight with Cheolsu hyung, and they made me promise. For their sake, I kept that promise. About a month after he dropped out, Cheolsu hyung enrolled in a college entrance academy in Noryangjin. He began studying again. That winter, he was accepted by a university in Pohang. His tuition and even his dormitory fees were fully waived. The day before he left for Pohang, he asked me to come outside with him. He took me to a pub in Sinchon and told me he was sorry for everything, that he wanted to apologize for what he had done, and that he was grateful I had endured it without getting angry at him. Then he gave me a book of poetry and a CD. They have both disappeared now after several moves, but I read that book and listened to that music countless times.

There was one thing I always wanted to apologize to my hyung for too. For a while, I had secretly read his diary. In the diary he kept hidden in the bottom

drawer of his desk were pages filled with disgust for the world and for human beings. He never named anyone in particular, but I knew at once that the person being cursed in those pages was his biological father. My aunt's sudden death had turned the secret into a mystery that could never be solved, but Cheolsu hyung cursed that unknown man and longed for him at the same time. There was no affection in that longing. Around the time Cheolsu hyung began studying for the entrance exams, I stopped reading his diary.

5

I opened my eyes because of a group of women in mourning clothes who were wailing loudly. Tears were also streaming from the eyes of a boy holding the funeral portrait of a young girl who looked to be about middle-school age. The cries continued for some time. I left the building to escape them. I drank coffee and smoked a cigarette. When the cremation was finished, I placed the urn in the columbarium. The driver had pulled the minibus up to the entrance and was waiting for me. We returned to the hospital morgue.

Back at my room, I filled the bathtub with hot water and soaked myself. Exhaustion came over me all at once. I collapsed onto the bed, tossed and turned, and when I finally got up, darkness had fallen outside the window. I was hungry, but I still had no appetite. I ordered a meal at a restaurant and left before I had eaten even half of it. I went into a bar near the hotel and drank several glasses of whiskey. The alcohol hit me quickly. I think I called my wife in Seoul, but I could

not remember what I said. My wife knew nothing about Cheolsu hyung. I had never told her that he existed. So she could not possibly understand why the detective had called me first, or why I was here alone arranging my hyung's funeral.

The next day, before returning to Seoul, I took a taxi to the address the detective had given me. It was a badly run-down apartment building near the Independence Hall of Korea. I stopped at the security office and collected the key. I gave the guard the money I had brought for him. He refused again and again, so I finally forced it into the pocket of his coat. According to the guard, my hyung had lived alone and no one ever came to visit him. When they happened to pass each other, Cheolsu hyung would give a small bow, but they had never really spoken. His neighbors did not know who he was or what he did for a living. They only knew that he was a quiet man. As I stepped into the elevator, the guard said,

“The smell was terrible, so we turned off the heating and left the windows open.”

After entering university, Cheolsu hyung rarely came to visit our home in Jangnpyeong. We left his small room exactly as it was, but even on holidays he would greet my parents and leave almost immediately. I learned much later that every time he came to our house, memories of his wounded childhood returned and caused him pain. I first heard what was really inside him when I was serving in the army. Cheolsu hyung came to visit me. Drunk, he told me the secrets he carried in his heart. Whenever he left our house, my mother used to press an envelope of spending money into his hand, but he always refused it. He said he earned enough money tutoring and did not need it. He said he could not remain indebted to them any longer. Indebted. That was when I understood that the word defined the relationship between Cheolsu hyung and our family. My father and mother treated

him as family, but to Cheolsu hyung, their kindness was a debt that would someday have to be repaid. Drunk in a shabby bar in Inje, he told me that he had turned down a national university in Seoul and gone all the way to Pohang because he no longer wanted to depend on my parents. That day, Cheolsu hyung also told me that when he was in his first year of high school, my uncle had come to see him at school once. Waiting for him by the school gate, my uncle handed him a bankbook in Cheolsu hyung's name and a small wooden seal. Then he told Cheolsu hyung that no matter what happened, he must never come looking for him. My uncle walked away. Cheolsu hyung remained standing there, watching him disappear into the distance. He said he saw the sorrow rising inside his chest turn into a tiny dot. He said he felt that tiny dot lodge in his bone marrow. Someday, he said, it felt as if that dot would devour him. At the time, I did not understand what he meant. Cheolsu hyung told me many things that day, but my thoughts kept drifting elsewhere. I kept thinking of the senior soldiers I would have to face again when I returned to the base. At that time in my life, I did not have the space inside me to truly listen to the hyung sitting in front of me.

The moment I opened the front door, the stench of a rotting corpse struck my nose. I covered it with a handkerchief and stepped inside. It was a small apartment with two rooms, a little living room, and a kitchen. Because of the bitter midwinter wind, the place was as cold as a freezer. A single bed stood alone in the smaller

room. The yellowed mattress brought back the horrifying image of my hyung's body. The larger room had been turned into a study. A black-and-white photograph of an empty bench hung on the wall. Books and records were neatly arranged on the shelves. On the desk lay open the book he must have been reading last. Beside it was a notebook covered with incomprehensible symbols, and next to that lay a fountain pen with dried ink. There were rice and flour in the cupboard and several bags of snacks whose expiration dates were still some time away. In the refrigerator were two half-finished bottles of water and several neatly arranged containers of side dishes. Everything was in order. Everything smelled of my hyung. Of my hyung rotting away.

There was a pile of unopened mail on the living-room table. I opened several of the envelopes. One was a bill from a telecommunications company. Another was a letter expressing regret that my hyung's paper could not be published in an academic journal. There was nothing valuable in the apartment. I gathered the mail and his laptop and went back into the study. I opened the book that had been lying on his desk. It was a physics book filled with difficult symbols and notation. His handwriting covered the pages here and there. As I tried to put the book back on the desk, an old card slipped out and fell at my feet. Tears burst from my eyes. It was the baseball card I had given him thirty years earlier. The player in the photograph wore an awkward smile. My tears fell onto the card.

After a long while, I pulled myself together and began searching the study. The diary was where it had always been, in the bottom drawer of the desk. I opened it. My hyung's life was there. As I read, I called his name silently.

After graduating from university, Cheolsu hyung went to the United States to study. His tuition was waived, and he even received living expenses. He never asked my parents for money. During all his years abroad, he never once returned to Korea. At the end of each year, he sent my parents a New Year's card by airmail. Whenever he could not concentrate on his studies, he would carve pictures into wooden boards with a chisel. Once, he sent me a woodblock calendar engraved with paintings by Lee Jung-seob.

My parents did not learn until much later that Cheolsu hyung had married in the United States and divorced the following year. When he told me about the marriage, I did not tell my parents. I no longer remember why. I think I no longer wanted to involve myself in his life. At the time, I was having enough trouble carrying my own. I also barely reacted when I learned that he had lost seven teeth while studying abroad and had dentures made as soon as he returned to Korea.

When Cheolsu hyung was appointed a professor of physics at a university in Seoul, my parents cautiously broached the subject of finding him a match. He refused. He said he had already failed at marriage in the United States and that living alone suited him. Then one day he simply disappeared. To ease my parents' worries, I went to the university where he had worked, only to be told that he had resigned from his professorship six months earlier and gone back to the United States. Our relatives cursed Cheolsu hyung as an ungrateful bastard. My parents said nothing. Cheolsu hyung did not attend my father's funeral. He did not attend my mother's funeral either. There was no way to tell a man who had evaporated from the world that my parents were dead. I did not blame him. I simply let him fade slowly from my memory.

His diary said again and again that he wanted to begin a new life somewhere no one knew him. It also said that he wanted to go back to being twelve years old. But Cheolsu hyung never returned to twelve. He died alone in the unfamiliar city of Cheonan. I could not understand him. But I could not hate him either. I wanted to tell him that I had loved and missed him as much as he had loved and missed me.

7

I hired a cleaning company to clear out the apartment. Everything my hyung had used was thrown away. We removed his smell, repapered the walls, and replaced the flooring. I left the inheritance matters to a lawyer introduced by someone from the legal team at my company.

A month has now passed since the funeral. I still see my hyung in my dreams. But he no longer appears as the grotesque figure in the photograph. I am grateful for that. My hyung is dead. Only now have I begun to accept it. My ordinary life is pushing him a little farther away from me each day. And yet, whenever I think of Cheolsu hyung, I still return to thirty-five years ago, to the day he came to our house holding my aunt's hand. While my aunt was asking my parents to take care of him for a little while, Cheolsu hyung suddenly disappeared. The adults, so absorbed in their conversation that they had not even noticed he was gone, finally realized his absence and went searching through the neighborhood. Even the neighbors joined them, but they could not find him before the sun went down and the moon rose.

In the empty house, with all the adults outside, I heard someone quietly sobbing. Cheolsu hyung was hiding alone behind the old car parked in our garage, crying. I did not shout to the adults that he was there. Instead, I crouched down beside him. Then I held out several of the professional baseball player cards I had collected. He did not take them. That was when he told me he wanted to disappear to a place where no one else existed, that he wanted to live there alone forever, and that place was not in this world. At the time, I had no idea what he meant. The memory of that day is no longer clear, but I can still hear the sound of my hyung quietly sobbing deep inside my chest. I hear that sobbing—the sound of sorrow gathering into a tiny dot and lodging deep in the boy’s chest.

Adjunct Lecturer K's 007 Briefcase

1

The moment K opened his eyes that morning, he reached for the 007 briefcase on the bedside table. He had bought it at a department store the day before, spending what felt like a fortune. For an adjunct lecturer living on meager pay, it was not an easy amount of money to part with. He had spent a substantial portion of his income on a new briefcase entirely because of J's advice. J, who had earned her doctorate a year before K, was now an assistant professor at Y University. She had told him several times that his old bag did not make a neat impression and that he should buy a new one. Each time, he had said he could not throw away the worn bag he had carried since his university days. It was frayed here and there, its color faded, and clumsy-looking, but K felt most comfortable carrying it. This time, however, it was hard to ignore J's advice.

K inspected the 007 briefcase carefully. He had examined even the stitching at the department store the day before, but he checked once more for scratches just in case. The sleek, trim briefcase was flawless. It really was a handsome thing, like something James Bond might have carried in a movie. It was no luxury brand, but K loved it. The handle, reinforced with cowhide, felt wonderfully soft in his hand.

He gently pressed the button beside the handle. With a sharp click of the locks, the briefcase opened smoothly. He was pleased with the interior as well. There seemed to be plenty of room for his laptop, the materials for his two lectures, and a slim book. There were separate compartments for a charger, pens, and a notebook. More than anything, what had won K over was the fact that the new 007 briefcase was waterproof. His old bag had always made him nervous whenever it rained. Once, a sudden downpour had soaked some of his students' assignments and lecture materials, causing him no end of trouble. Ever since then, he had kept a large plastic bag folded inside one corner of his bag. Whenever it rained, he would wrap his laptop and important papers in it first. Even he could not deny that it made him look rather shabby and cheap.

K got out of bed and, still in his pajamas, picked up the briefcase and tried walking with it. He carried it all the way into the living room. He shifted it from his right hand to his left. Even the smooth transfer of the briefcase from one hand to the other seemed to have a certain precision to it. He remembered the first small handbag he had been given as a child and how he had carried it around all day. He had taken that little bag with him while eating and even when going to the bathroom. It had been almost an extension of himself. K found himself slightly ridiculous, putting on this whole performance with his 007 briefcase first thing in the morning. He let out a hearty laugh and went into the bathroom.

After a simple breakfast, K went into the master bedroom to pack his briefcase. The small rental apartment where he lived had two rooms. He used the master bedroom as a study and the smaller room facing the corridor as his bedroom.

Sleeping there was somewhat uncomfortable, but there was nothing he could do about it. He would simply have to put up with it until his circumstances improved.

K had two classes that day. At A University he was to teach Introduction to Political Philosophy, and at Y University he would lead a discussion on the political thought of Marx and Lenin. A University was only a little over a ten-minute walk from his apartment, but Y University was much farther away and required more than an hour by bus and subway. He began arranging the materials he would put in the briefcase. Two textbooks, three reference books, his laptop, and a thick file that he decided to place at the very bottom. The file was packed with propaganda posters and photographs from the Russian Revolution, newspaper articles, and black-and-white photographs of demonstrations that he had collected over the years. There were crowds raising red flags, soldiers carrying rifles, Lenin standing at a podium, and old propaganda images bearing the hammer and sickle. They were all materials for his lectures, but seen without explanation, they might make someone mistake K for an antiquated revolutionary. K sometimes showed these materials to his students and told them that an era and its ideas had to be read separately. The fact that an idea was old did not mean there was no longer any need to study it.

Ready to leave for work, K drank coffee in the living room. He was careful not to stain the pale gray suit J had bought him the day before. As he set down his cup, he remembered J saying that now that she had secured a position, they should marry in the fall as they had promised. Several years earlier, they had agreed to marry as soon as one of them obtained a full-time faculty position. When K returned to Korea after studying abroad, he had believed he would soon find a place at a

university. Every former professor and senior colleague he met had offered the same encouraging words. He had been confident himself. That was why he had been the one to bring up marriage in the first place. But it had not taken long for him to realize that his expectations were merely expectations. Even finding a single course to teach was difficult. There was no shortage of PhDs. No one was eager to offer him a position. Little by little, his energy drained away. His family was not particularly well off, and his own circumstances became steadily more precarious. At some point he began to wonder whether returning to Korea had been a mistake. Even his first teaching job, obtained with great difficulty, had come through J. She had handed over to K one of the courses that had originally been offered to her.

K took a deep breath. Then he picked up the 007 briefcase in his right hand, went to the entrance, and put on his shoes. Unlike his new suit and new briefcase, the shoes were badly worn. The heel of the left shoe in particular had worn down so much that even when he stood still, he felt as though his body tilted to the left. Since he had already started buying new things, K decided he might as well buy a new pair of shoes too. Perhaps his shabby appearance was the reason he had still not escaped the life of a traveling academic peddler.

2

The class at A University ended without incident. The student assigned to give a presentation said nothing especially remarkable, but K was pleased simply because the student had clearly read the assigned text carefully. K was grateful to the

students who had chosen his course. If enrollment fell below a certain number, the class could be canceled. If that happened, there was no guarantee he would have a course to teach the following semester. He had no intention of currying favor with students just to be popular, but he did need to make sure they did not find the class unbearably difficult. Still, more than anything, K wanted to teach well. He believed that was the only reason he stood in front of a classroom.

Just as K was about to leave, one student stood up and called out loudly.

“Professor, the suit and briefcase look great, but the shoes don’t match. If you’ve got an important appointment today, you should buy yourself a new pair.”

The students burst out laughing. Several in the back even leaned forward to get a look at K’s shoes. K smiled at them awkwardly.

When K stepped outside the building, several students from his class were standing near the vending machines, chatting.

“Professor, are you really going on a blind date today?”

It was the student who had told him to buy new shoes.

“Stop worrying about things that have nothing to do with you and study for the exam.”

K gave a faint grin.

“Professor, about the midterm. Couldn’t you cut down the material a little?

Everyone’s complaining that there’s too much to read.”

“Everyone, or you?”

“Lecturer, come on. Who reads Marx in the original language these days? And making us read Lenin too is a bit much, isn’t it? We’re already overwhelmed with job hunting.”

K looked at the student.

“You mean old books aren’t worth reading?”

“That’s not what I mean. But honestly, it’s not like this stuff helps us get jobs. The seniors say courses like this are just about getting a decent grade anyway. They say we’d be better off spending the time studying for certifications.”

“If universities taught only what helped people get jobs, what would we need universities for?”

The student fell silent for a moment, then shrugged.

“Isn’t that how everyone thinks these days?”

“You chose the course. Whether you take the exam or not, whether you study or not, that’s your affair. But I have no intention of reducing the material.”

He was a shrewd student. Until moments ago he had unfailingly called K “Professor,” but the instant things stopped going his way, the title had become “Lecturer.” That tiny change in address bothered K more than he wanted to admit. For a moment, he wondered whether to the student Marx, Lenin, and K himself had all become equally obsolete. He said nothing more. He had no desire to argue with a student over something so pointless.

After lunch, K took his coffee outside and sat on a bench. He smoked a cigarette and checked the time. He still had a little while before his class at Y University. The 007 briefcase beside the bench looked splendid. He stood up and looked at it from a couple of steps away. It really was a sleek, handsome thing. Just as he was about to sit down again, he saw the department chair approaching from some distance away. K hurriedly put out his cigarette and went over to greet him.

“So, do you have a moment?”

The chair barely acknowledged K's greeting before asking the question.

"Me? I have a class at Y University this afternoon, so I was just about to leave. Is something wrong?"

"I see. How about this evening, then?"

"That's fine. I don't have any plans after my class at Y."

"Good. Contact me at my office when you finish."

"All right. But what is this about...?"

"It's good news for you. We'll talk about it properly over dinner. Professor Park and Professor Lee will be joining us."

"I understand. I'll contact you as soon as class is over."

"I'll choose the restaurant. And buy yourself a new pair of shoes. You stand in front of university students, for heaven's sake. Look at them. Your briefcase and suit are perfectly neat. If a man wants to look properly put together, he has to pay attention to his shoes and his watch too."

Having said this, the chair strode away before K even had a chance to bow again. K had a fair idea why he wanted to see him that evening. It was probably about the full-time faculty position the department planned to fill that semester. K had quietly allowed himself some hope, but he had not expected the chair to approach him first. Because he had not graduated from A University, he was at a disadvantage in several respects. But he was hardly in a position to be particular about alma maters. He had been thinking of visiting the chair himself before long. Instead, the chair had asked to see him first. And professors with considerable influence in the university would be there as well. K tried not to get his hopes up. He had learned more than once that the greater the expectation, the greater the disappointment.

A glance at the time told him he would be cutting it close getting to Y University. K hesitated over whether to take a taxi. A taxi would swallow a substantial part of what he earned from teaching that day. He could not do that. Carrying the 007 briefcase, he began walking quickly. But he kept noticing his shoes. They seemed to throw his entire appearance out of balance. Looking down at them as he walked, K suddenly realized that he dragged his left foot along the ground. He tried to make sure the shoe did not scrape when he stepped forward with his left foot. Each time he did, however, his whole body seemed to lose its balance. Once he nearly stumbled. He gave up the unnatural gait and simply let his left foot skim the ground as he walked. Almost immediately, walking felt comfortable again.

3

At first K thought the man was a pickpocket. The bus was not crowded, yet the man ignored plenty of open space and stood beside him. But even an idiot would hardly try to pick someone's pocket alone on a bus this empty. The man wore jeans long out of fashion and an old denim jacket. His large eyes, which looked perpetually on the verge of tears, drooped heavily at the outer corners, and thick eyebrows lay almost in a straight line across his narrow forehead. His ears stuck oddly forward. His features seemed crowded together around his nose, forming a face that could hardly be called welcoming. He was not particularly tall and was rather thin. Altogether, there was something vaguely ill-assembled about him.

K had been on guard when the man first came near, but the man's slight build reassured him somewhat; he thought he could overpower him if necessary. He did not relax completely. K waited for a seat to open up. As soon as one did, he intended to get away from the man and sit down. When a seat became free in the very back, K casually moved there. The man did not follow. K began to think he had suspected an innocent person. The world was dangerous enough these days, he told himself; it was not entirely his fault that such thoughts occurred to him. At the next stop, many passengers got off. Empty seats appeared here and there. A little later, however, the man came and sat beside K. There were plenty of seats where he could have sat alone, yet he had deliberately chosen the one beside him. K looked out the window and pretended not to notice. It was a languid afternoon. The sort of fine weather that made work seem pointless and made a person want to go somewhere, anywhere, just for a change of air. While remaining conscious of the man beside him, K also thought about his dinner with the department chair. His mind was tangled with thoughts of whether he might finally obtain a full-time position. Then the man spoke.

"Let's split what's in that briefcase fifty-fifty. Then I won't report you."

"What?"

K stared at him in surprise.

"I said I won't report you if we split it. I know exactly what you've got in there."

"What are you talking about? Who are you?"

"You don't need to know that. Are we splitting it, or are we going to the police station?"

K was utterly bewildered. The briefcase contained nothing but his teaching materials, laptop, and file. The very idea of splitting its contents made no sense.

“Look, there are only books and lecture materials in this briefcase. You’ve got the wrong idea, so stop bothering me.”

K’s voice was edged with irritation. But the man smirked as though he had expected exactly that response and reached for the briefcase.

“Then let’s have a look. Let’s see what’s inside.”

K hurriedly pushed the man's hand away.

“Who are you to tell me to open my briefcase? Are you out of your mind?”

“Come now.”

The man tried to look intimidating.

“Then come to the police station with me.”

People had begun to notice the argument, and one by one they turned to look. K felt deeply uncomfortable. He could not keep arguing with a madman, but he could not simply get off the bus either. He was already short on time for class.

“Listen, I teach at a university. Stop bothering me. You’ve obviously misunderstood something, so let’s end this here.”

“Then show me what’s in the briefcase. That solves everything, doesn’t it? You won’t show me because you’ve got something shady in there.”

“Are you insane?”

K suddenly raised his voice. The man was not intimidated in the slightest.

“I already know everything, so why are you acting like this? Let’s split it right down the middle. No point making a scene. Even half would set us up nicely.”

“You’re crazy. You’re completely out of your mind.”

K could stand no more and got to his feet. The man grabbed his sleeve. The corners of the man's drooping eyes rose until they were almost level. It was probably as high as he could make them go. K shook off his hand and headed toward the door.

"Come now."

The man stared at K as though K were the unreasonable one.

After getting off at the stop, K walked quickly without looking back. Fast enough that his shins began to ache. As he walked, he glanced down to see whether his left foot was still brushing the ground because his gait felt unnatural. Before he could check, he heard the man shouting angrily behind him.

"Stop him!"

K turned. The man was chasing him. K was more than a little alarmed. He had clearly checked that the man had not followed him off the bus, yet somehow there he was, running after him. K had no choice but to run if he did not want to be caught. Why he had to run from the man, he could not have said. At that moment, not being caught was his only goal.

An alley seemed better than the main road. Stop him! continued to lash at his ears. K spotted a narrow side street and darted into it. He kept running. Never before had he possessed such a clear objective. He had gone abroad to study without necessarily intending to earn a doctorate. He simply enjoyed reading old books and arguing with people who had long since died. Nor had he chosen Marx and Lenin because of any particular ideological conviction. He had simply wanted to know why people who believed they could explain the world completely had ended up making such a mess of it. One thing had led to another, and he had

earned a doctorate. Now he taught at universities, but K was not certain that becoming a professor was truly his dream. His students regarded the ideas he taught as relics, and universities handed such courses off to adjunct lecturers semester by semester. K did not need some grand title. All he wanted was a stable position that would allow him to earn a living while continuing to read and think. Being a professor might simply be the most comfortable job he could hope for.

His phone rang. It was J. Gasping for breath, K told her he could not talk and would call later. Alarmed, J asked what had happened. K hurriedly said that someone was chasing him and that he would call her back, then ended the call and kept running.

His back was soaked with sweat. Beads of perspiration covered his forehead. How long had he been running? He could no longer hear the cry of Stop him! K was so badly out of breath that breathing itself had become difficult. Each time he swallowed, his dry throat burned and his chest felt tight. He leaned against a wall on trembling legs and tried to catch his breath. Then he noticed his own shadow, bent nearly double and panting. Looking at that miserable shadow, he slowly sank to the ground.

Perhaps all he had to do was open the briefcase and show the man what was inside. But he did not want to. His pride would not allow it, and more than that, there was no telling what absurd accusation the man might make after seeing the materials in the briefcase. The thought of opening a file filled with red flags, photographs of Lenin, and revolutionary propaganda in front of a man like that and having to explain it all was unbearable. It was all because of the 007 briefcase. When K carried his old bag, no one had ever given him a second glance. Today

people had already looked at him several times because of his appearance, and now he was being chased by a man whose identity he did not even know. Still breathing heavily, K got to his feet and braced one hand against the wall. He loosened his tie and unbuttoned the top button of his shirt. Once his breathing had steadied, he began walking slowly. He contacted Y University to say that he would be a little late for class. When he emerged onto the main road again, he saw the entrance to a subway station in the distance.

4

The subway car was quiet. Sitting down, K regretted not taking a taxi. His reflection appeared in the window opposite him. Dressed up in a new suit and carrying a new briefcase, he looked pathetic. The fact that some bizarre stranger had forced him to run through the streets made him seem ridiculous even to himself. If he had known this was what all those years of hard study would lead to, perhaps he should simply have stayed abroad.

These days K found it difficult to face his father and elder brother, who had helped pay for his studies abroad despite their own limited means. What troubled him most, however, was J. Of course he loved her. But the persistent feeling that he was falling behind her only deepened his self-contempt. She had secured a position almost immediately after returning from abroad, while he felt as though he were still circling somewhere near the starting line. He was ashamed that even as he wanted her to succeed, he also felt a strange sense of competition with her. Perhaps,

K thought, he was even jealous of her. Then he remembered that he needed to call J back. He was reaching for his phone when it rang first.

“What happened earlier? You had me worried.”

There was a faint tremor in J’s voice.

“It was nothing. Some strange man suddenly started chasing me, so I had to run.”

K felt ridiculous saying it aloud.

“What? Someone was chasing you?”

“I’ll explain later. Anyway, could we cancel our plans tonight? You know the chair at A University? He wants to see me this evening.”

“Then could you stop by my office after class? It’ll only take a minute, but I’d rather not say it over the phone.”

“All right. I’ll come by as soon as class is over.”

After ending the call, K looked out the window. The train was crossing the Han River. For a while he stared blankly at the water. The surface rippled gently in the breeze, and a lone bird, from wherever it had come, circled over the river. Then someone tapped him on the shoulder.

“Mister, I told you. Let’s split what’s in that briefcase.”

K nearly screamed. The man he had been certain he had escaped was sitting beside him. K instinctively realized that something had gone seriously wrong. He decided that avoiding the man was the only sensible course. He did not want to create a scene on the train and attract everyone’s attention. The train was entering the underground section again. The man seemed to be mocking him, as if to say there was no point in running. K wanted badly to slap him across the face, but he

suppressed his rising anger and quietly moved into the next car. The man followed like a shadow. K moved into another car. The man followed again.

By the time K reached the last car, he had decided to get off at the next station. He would leave the station and take a taxi.

“Running away again? I’m not asking for all of it. Don’t be so stingy.”

Now the man sounded irritated, as though he were the one whose patience had run out.

K did not answer. He waited for the train to stop. He had no intention of running anymore. Once he got outside and caught a taxi, it would all be over.

“Listen, if you’re thinking of running again, you might as well give up now.”

There was an understated threat in the man’s voice.

K continued to ignore him, waiting only for the doors to open. An announcement came over the speakers saying the train would remain stopped briefly to maintain distance from the train ahead. K grew increasingly restless. He wanted to forget the class, forget everything, and simply go somewhere far away.

When the doors opened, K quietly stepped off and walked toward the exit. The man followed without a word. At the gate, K tapped his transit card against the reader. An error tone sounded and a warning appeared on the screen. He tried again, with the same result. K was confused. He distinctly remembered tapping in normally when he boarded. He checked the app on his phone, but the entry record was missing. It was utterly baffling. For a moment K suspected the man, but he had no desire to get into another argument with him. He approached a station attendant. He assumed that once he explained the situation, it would be resolved quickly.

“Excuse me, there seems to be something wrong with my transit card. I definitely tapped in when I entered, but there’s no record of it. I’m on my way to teach a class at Y University, and I’m running a little late.”

K spoke politely.

“Let me check.”

The attendant examined the card and the gate records as though it were nothing unusual.

Then the man cut in.

“Mister, this guy’s lying. He’s been trying to sneak through from the beginning.”

“What?”

The attendant looked puzzled.

“He’s fare-dodging.” Before K could defend himself, the man continued. “I’ve been watching him the whole time.”

The attendant called over a colleague and asked K to come into the station office for a moment while they checked. K insisted that he had tapped in normally. The attendant said it would only take a little more time to verify the records. K explained that he was already late for class and asked whether they could not simply deal with it there, but it made no difference. He glared at the man. He felt ready to explode. The man only kept grinning.

The man followed them all the way into the station office. In a loud voice he began ranting about people who refused to follow public transportation rules, about how someone without even the most basic civic consciousness could presume to teach other people. K could tolerate that much. But when the man said that

someone who taught university students yet evaded his fare ought to be properly investigated, K could take no more.

“You crazy bastard. Do you want to get yourself killed today?”

K shouted at the top of his voice.

“Well, look at that. Going to hit me now? Go ahead. Hit me.”

The man came right back at him.

The station staff stepped between them, but K could not calm down.

“May I see some identification?”

“Why do you need my ID?”

“We just need to confirm who you are and check the trip record.”

K took his identification out of his wallet.

“Look. I teach at a university. Why would I evade a subway fare? The card simply didn’t register properly. And this man has been following me around since earlier, saying all kinds of insane things. He’s been trailing me like some kind of stalker. I’m losing my mind here. I’m supposed to be teaching at Y University right now. Please check it and let me go.”

“Would you like us to call the police?”

“What?”

“If this gentleman has been following and threatening you, it might be better to speak to the police.”

“Yes, call them,” the man cut in. “And here’s a secret I suppose I’ll have to reveal now. There’s something astonishing in this man’s briefcase. So call the police.”

“You crazy bastard.”

The curse escaped K before he knew it. The air inside the office suddenly turned cold.

“That won’t be necessary. What do I need to do about the card? I have a class to teach, so please just deal with this quickly.”

“See that?” the man shouted. “The second someone mentions the police, he backs down. That proves he’s hiding something. You can’t just let him go.”

K was already considerably late for class. All he wanted was to escape this revolting situation. At that moment, a uniformed police officer entered the station office.

“What’s going on?”

“There’s something strange in this man’s briefcase.”

The man spoke before K had a chance.

“This man has been following me around, telling me to split whatever is in my briefcase with him. My name is K. I teach at a university. My transit card record got messed up, and now he’s lying to the station staff and saying I evaded the fare. I’m already late for class. I need to go.”

“He’s lying through his teeth.”

“What’s in the briefcase?”

“Teaching materials, my laptop, things like that.”

“May I take a look?”

“No.”

“See? I told you he’s hiding something.”

The man smiled in triumph.

The police officer looked at K for a moment.

“If you open the briefcase, we can settle this immediately. If it contains nothing but teaching materials, as you say, that will be the end of it.”

“Why should I have to? What have I done wrong?”

“I’m not saying I’m going to force you to open it. If you don’t want to, we’ll have to follow a different procedure, but that may take longer.”

K realized that the situation was turning against him. He should not have lost his temper. It was too late to regret it now. His pride was badly wounded. The idea of having to open his briefcase in front of other people was humiliating. But it was the only way to get out of the situation quickly. K placed the briefcase on the desk. He entered the combination and pressed the button beside the handle. Click. The briefcase opened smoothly. K stepped back, and the officer began looking inside. He lifted out the laptop, the Korean-language textbooks, and the English reference books, then opened the thick file beneath them. The first page held a photograph of a crowd waving red flags. The next showed Lenin speaking from a podium. After that came posters bearing the hammer and sickle and photographs of soldiers carrying rifles.

The officer’s hand stopped for a moment.

“What’s this?”

K sighed without meaning to.

“Lecture materials.”

“For a class?”

“I teach Marx and Lenin. They’re for my political philosophy course.”

The officer turned several more pages. K could barely stand having the station staff and the man stare into his briefcase. Suddenly it seemed absurd that the things

to which he had devoted his life could look suspicious unless accompanied by an explanation.

“Universities teach things like this?”

“Yes. For now.”

The words sounded strangely as if they were about K himself.

The officer closed the file.

“I understand. I’m sorry we troubled you unnecessarily.”

“Can I go now?”

K said nothing more. He had no desire to offer pathetic explanations. He wanted only to escape this absurd situation.

“Yes. Sorry for the inconvenience.”

The station attendant checked the card record once more and said that it appeared to have been a reader error and that no further action was necessary.

As K gathered his briefcase, he raised his head and stared hard at the man, his mouth clenched tight. Seeing the look on K’s face, the officer asked whether he wished to file a complaint against him. The man immediately started arguing again, insisting that K must have moved the goods somewhere else, that there had to be accomplices, and that they should investigate him at once. But no one was listening anymore. The officer shouted at the man to be quiet, then again asked K whether he wanted to file a complaint. K stared at the man for a long moment before speaking.

“Let him go about ten minutes after I leave. And maybe check whether there have been any missing-person reports while you’re at it.”

The classroom was empty. On one side of the electronic board were the words CLASS CANCELED. K could not hide his sense of futility. After everything it had taken to get there, it had all been for nothing. The students had apparently waited for a long time, contacted the teaching assistant, and the class had eventually been canceled. K went to the window and opened it slightly. He took a cigarette from his pocket, looked at it for a while, then put it back. There was nowhere inside the building where he could smoke anymore.

“So April really is the cruelest month,” K murmured. April in London had been cruel. The rain never stopped, and his whole body had always felt damp. He had needed to carry an umbrella everywhere. And yet his mind had been at ease. Seoul was the opposite. The April sky was as clear as could be, but his heart felt unbearably heavy.

Leaning against the lectern, K thought about his dinner with the department chair that evening. If he obtained a full-time position, many things might change. He would no longer have to worry at the end of every semester about whether he would have classes the next one. His name would no longer simply vanish from the university system one day. He would not have to keep asking other people for help whenever electronic resources were unavailable through his lecturer account. He could apply for research funding and perhaps continue teaching the courses he

wanted to teach for more than a semester at a time. More than anything, perhaps he would no longer feel as though he were being hired all over again every semester.

Would being a regular member of the faculty make him feel a little more legitimate? Would he no longer have to explain who he was while opening his briefcase in front of a police officer? Would it stop bothering him when a student changed from “Professor” to “Lecturer”? Perhaps pride itself was a luxury for someone trapped in the life of an adjunct lecturer. K found it almost laughable that a man in such an unstable position should concern himself with pride at all. His dinner with the department chair that evening might become a major turning point in his life. If he became a full-time faculty member, he would no longer have to postpone marrying J, and his life would be more stable than it was now. And yet K did not feel at ease. The position he had wanted for so long now seemed close enough to touch, but he could no longer tell whether he truly wanted it.

K looked at the 007 briefcase on the lectern. It was sleek and handsome. That morning he had liked it so much, but now it somehow seemed wrong for him. The neat gray suit he was wearing felt cumbersome too, as though he had borrowed someone else’s clothes. The old shoes with their worn-down heels felt more comfortable than anything else. K picked up the 007 briefcase and walked out of the classroom. He thought that perhaps he and J should drive somewhere just outside the city that weekend and get some air. In the long, dim corridor, students whose classes had ended stood in groups of two and three, talking among themselves. K walked with his left foot lightly dragging across the floor. His lonely shadow slowly faded amid the students’ voices.

Aftershock

1

“If my name hadn’t been Munja, I would’ve lived a much cooler life.”

Munja said this when she came over to my apartment, around the time the cherry blossoms had fallen and the roadside trees were beginning to turn green. The late-afternoon sunlight reached deep into the living room.

“What happened to changing your name?”

Lately Munja had been saying all the time that she was going to file a petition with the family court to change her name.

“I will. Soon.”

“Have you thought of a name?”

“How about Subin?”

“Doesn’t that sound a little young?”

“Maybe. Then what about Misu or Suyeong?”

“Do you like names with *su* in them?”

“Now that you mention it, I guess I do.” Munja smiled. “But if I change my name, will my life get better?”

I say nothing for a moment. What kind of change can a new name bring to a life? Of course something will change, but how can anyone know whether that change will be for the better or not? Munja stares at me, waiting for an answer.

“Sure. It’ll get better.”

I say something I don’t mean. Lately, I have started lying again. I no longer want to make the people around me uncomfortable by always telling the truth.

“Right? I’m sure it will.”

One reason I like Munja is that she understands what discretion means. She knows what should be done and what should not. And she never puts on an act just to impress other people. I first met Munja at work. Strictly speaking, though, that isn’t true. I learned later that Munja and I had gone to the same elementary school and graduated from the same university. We simply hadn’t known each other. Perhaps we had passed each other once or twice at an elementary-school sports day or a university festival.

A year after graduating from college, I finally managed to get a job as the lowest-ranking employee in the PR office of a subsidiary of a large corporation. Munja was in charge of turning our company’s history into a book. She was a graphic designer who had studied industrial design at art school. She did not work for our company but for a publishing house that did business with our PR agency. Contractually, that made us Party A and Party C. Party A sounded grand, but as the youngest employee in the PR office, I had almost nothing to do except run errands. I was inexperienced at everything, got scolded every single day, and smoked countless cigarettes while stewing over it all. Munja, though, was different. She was only in her third year as a designer, but she was good at what she did. More than

that, she understood how work actually moved and how decisions were made. The working-level staff listened to her opinions, and the proposals she backed usually won the approval of the final decision-maker without much trouble. My seniors in PR even told me to learn from Park Munja.

Once, when I was on the company rooftop smoking and trying to cool down, Munja came over. We smoked without saying anything. The yellow dust was especially bad that day, and visibility was poor. My head was full of thoughts about quitting the company I had struggled so hard to get into, and doubts about whether I would ever be able to pull my weight there. I smoked another cigarette. After work, we went somewhere well away from the office and had beer. That was when we discovered that we had gone to the same elementary school and the same university. That was how our friendship began.

When the project ended, Munja moved to a large publishing house. She changed jobs several more times after that. Two years ago, she left office life altogether and began working as a freelance designer. I know she has made enough of a name for herself in publishing that she never runs short of work. We didn't talk all the time, but we called now and then to see how the other was doing, and every couple of months we would go out for drinks. Neither of us stood on pride and waited for the other to call first.

Munja was still unmarried, and I had not remarried since my divorce seven years earlier. It wasn't that I had never met a woman I liked, but I no longer wanted to share my daily life with anyone. If someone took one step toward me, I took two steps back. Living alone no longer bothered me. And by now I was doing reasonably well at work. I was a team manager in PR, and someday I might even

become head of PR. I was no longer the awkward person I had once been. I still wasn't sure, though, whether I truly liked the work.

Munja's appearance began to change when she reached her mid-thirties. She had never been strikingly beautiful, but as her very thin frame filled out a little with age, her intelligent air became more pronounced. Even the way she brushed her disheveled hair back with one hand looked rather stylish. After ten years of knowing her, she could still seem as fresh as someone I had met yesterday. And yet she was always comfortable to be around. I thought I was lucky to have a friend like that.

A few years ago, when Munja was seriously considering marriage, I genuinely encouraged her. I remember asking, "Does he make you laugh?" and watching her shake her head. I felt a little sad then. Looking back, I think my own marriage fell apart so early because we failed to make each other laugh. When there's no money, love tends to cool. But even without love, a marriage can limp along if there's enough money. To keep a marriage healthy, though, laughter is essential. If the thought of him or her doesn't bring a smile to your face, the conclusion is obvious.

For whatever reason, Munja did not marry the man. If she had, our friendship probably would have ended. It wasn't that I found Munja sexually unattractive. Strangely, though, I had no desire to sleep with her. I felt that if I did, I might lose a friend. The absence of sex gave me comfort. I didn't have to exaggerate or show off to impress her. I am sometimes curious about what Munja thinks of me. But I have never asked her. Maybe I am finally old enough to understand what discretion means myself.

“I think I’ve lived too timidly because of my name.” Munja stood up from the sofa. “Should we get going?”

2

Munja and I went to a new French restaurant near her apartment. Her apartment was three blocks from mine. Munja ordered coq au vin, chicken braised in wine, and I ordered an Alsatian dish of sausage and steamed potatoes. We also had a bottle of reasonably priced Bordeaux.

“My father says he’s going to transfer a small studio apartment into my name. My oldest brother called this morning.”

“What are you going to do?”

Munja was silent for a moment. These days she barely spoke to her father, and at some point she had stopped going to his house altogether. After learning how he had accumulated his wealth, she declared that she would not inherit a single won from him. It wasn’t hard to imagine her father, a former military general turned lobbyist, flying into a rage. Her brother and sister had tried to arrange a reconciliation, but Munja always refused.

“What do you mean, what am I going to do? I told them I don’t want it. It’s dirty money. You saw it on the news too.”

“Then that settles it.”

“I’m glad I take after my mother. If I’d taken after my father’s side like my brother and sister, I wouldn’t have been able to be friends with you.”

“Why?”

“I don’t know.” Munja shrugged. “But I know. I know that’s how it would’ve been.”

Just then my phone rang. I didn’t answer. I put it back into the inside pocket of my jacket.

“Who is it? Why aren’t you answering?”

“Work.”

“Work? On a Saturday night? What if it’s urgent?”

“No. It’s just a bit of a nuisance.”

“What happened?”

For a moment I hesitate over whether to tell Munja about the incident. I take a sip of wine. Munja watches me with curiosity.

“You know I went to Japan on a business trip last March?”

“When the earthquake happened?”

“Something bad happened then.”

“Didn’t you say everybody came home without getting hurt?”

“We were in Tokyo. Nobody was injured.”

“So?”

Again I hesitate over whether to tell her more.

At 2:46 p.m. on March 11, when a massive earthquake struck the Tohoku region of Japan, I was in Shinjuku, Tokyo. Three days earlier, I had come to Osaka on business with Executive Director Park Jinwoo from the PR office. That morning we took the Shinkansen to Tokyo. Manager Kim Minseo, who had arrived in Tokyo two days before us, had finished all the preparations for the afternoon meeting and

was waiting. I had lunch with executives from the Tokyo office, and at two o'clock we began a PR strategy meeting. We were deep in discussion when it felt as if someone had kicked the conference table. At first I thought someone had done it by accident, but when the table jolted a second and a third time, Executive Director Park suddenly snapped, asking who was kicking it. No one was. It was an earthquake. Neither Park nor I had ever experienced one before, so when the table first began to tremble, neither of us realized what was happening. I felt terribly dizzy. The water in a dispenser in the corner of the conference room sloshed back and forth.

The first thing to fall was the monitor remote lying near the edge of the conference table. When it hit the floor, its batteries popped out. Before the rolling batteries could reach the wall, a fifty-inch monitor toppled helplessly inward onto the table. My body went rigid as I stared through the conference-room windows. The high-rises of Shinjuku were swaying slightly from side to side. The shaking made it hard to keep my balance. Frames containing the company's management philosophy and corporate motto fell from the walls. Shards of glass scattered everywhere. The conference table began heaving violently from side to side again. The large monitor slid off the table and smashed onto the floor. The conference room was a wreck. The building shook as if it might collapse at any moment. A wall clock that had fallen to the floor showed 2:48. There was a sharp creak as the conference-room door twisted in its frame. I had no idea how long the earthquake had been going on. One minute, two minutes, ten minutes. I could hear people screaming outside the conference room, followed by the dull crash of something falling over.

I was afraid the building would collapse and bury me beneath concrete rubble. If it did, I hoped I would die instantly, without pain. Only a few minutes earlier, I had had no idea death could be so close. I took my phone out of my suit jacket. I wanted to call the first person who had come into my mind. I felt I couldn't die without saying the words I had kept inside for so long. Then the earthquake suddenly stopped.

A web of fine cracks spread across the conference-room walls like the veins of leaves. It took a long time to walk down from the seventeenth-floor office to the lobby because people from every floor had crowded into the emergency stairwell. No one rushed. They calmly followed the person in front of them. The emergency lights in the stairwell did not come on. People had no choice but to make their way carefully by the light of their phones. When I finally got outside, the first thing I saw was a utility pole lying on the ground, uprooted.

"So? What was the bad thing that happened?"

"Can I tell you later? I don't feel like talking about it right now."

For a while neither of us spoke. Munja seemed lost in thought too, fingering her wineglass as she looked out the window. A young couple passed by pushing a stroller, and an elderly couple followed slowly a few steps behind. A boy on a bicycle sped past them.

"Something happened a long time ago."

Munja turned and looked at me.

"When I was serving as a KATUSA, our company first sergeant once said we should all go out for dinner together. The senior soldiers who were close to him probably liked those dinners, but what was there for a PFC like me to enjoy? I'd

just have to wait on them. But there wasn't much choice. If he said we were going, we went. Anyway, after work that Saturday, we all got overnight passes and went to a sashimi restaurant in Noryangjin Market."

"And?"

"There was a private named Hosik in our admin office. He couldn't drink at all. But instead of saying so, he froze up and drank everything they handed him. Then suddenly he had a seizure. I really thought Hosik was going to die."

"Good thing he didn't."

"Of course he didn't. We made him throw up everything he'd drunk and rubbed his hands and feet. It was chaos for a while. After about thirty minutes he got a little better. So the company first sergeant told PFC Kim and me to take Hosik home. His family ran a restaurant near Yeongdeungpo Station."

"His parents must've been terrified."

"They were. Hosik's mother asked if he'd been drinking. I told her he hadn't had very much. Then PFC Kim corrected me. He said no, Hosik had drunk a lot, and that was why he'd had the seizure. I still don't know why I lied like that. Why I didn't just tell the truth."

I felt my face grow hot.

"Munja, after that day I decided I would never lie again just to get myself out of an awkward situation. But it turned out not to be as easy as I thought."

Our conversation stopped for a moment while the waiter cleared the dishes from our table.

"And?"

"That's it. PFC Kim and I left Hosik's family restaurant and went home."

“Sometimes I think about PFC Kim. I’m sure he’s doing fine.”

My phone rang again. Munja stared at me. I switched it off. A little later I switched it back on and told Munja I was going outside to make a call. I left the restaurant and made the call. When I finished and returned to the table, Munja was resting her chin on her left hand, apparently deep in thought.

“What is it?”

“That’s my line.”

“It was that guy from work who called earlier. Manager Kim Minseo, the one who was with me on the Japan trip. Why do you look so serious?”

“It’s nothing.”

“Then why that face?”

“If I change my name, I feel like I’ll be separated from my family forever. The only thread still connecting me to them is the name Munja.”

Munja gave an awkward smile and emptied the wine left in her glass.

“Should we go? I’ve got a good bottle of whisky at home. What do you think?”
Munja said.

Darkness had settled over the streets. It took less than ten minutes to walk from the restaurant to Munja’s apartment. Perhaps because the apartment complex was newly built, the trees were not very tall. The young trees, standing there with their

roots in the ground, looked precarious. Munja's building was at the far end of the complex. By the time we had climbed the long slope, I was out of breath.

"People who smoke like us can't live up here. You'd die from the climb," I said.

"I don't want to quit. There's nobody around to nag me about smoking, so why should I?"

"Want me to nag you?"

"You quit first. Then I'll consider it."

When Munja opened her apartment door, an old Chihuahua tried to get up, gave up, and merely made an effort to raise its head. Munja went into the living room, picked up the dog, and stroked its head and back. The Chihuahua's lower abdomen was swollen.

"Aji doesn't have much time left. She's already thirteen. They say that's like being in your eighties if you're human."

"What does the vet say?"

"They say she probably won't make it through the spring. The vet says the tumor has gotten so big I should start considering euthanasia."

"When a dog you've lived with dies, it's hard for a while."

"I suppose it will be. When Aji dies, I don't think I'll ever be able to have another pet."

"A lot of people say that."

Munja and I sat on the living-room sofa and began drinking whisky. The Chihuahua lay at our feet, rubbing its face against us. Looking at the sick dog made me feel sorry for it. Then suddenly there was a heavy thud from the ceiling. The whole apartment shook for a moment as if we were inside a giant drum. Even the

living-room windows trembled from the vibration. My expression stiffened. So did my body.

“The people upstairs make noises like that sometimes. What on earth are they doing?”

“I felt seasick for a second. Ever since that big earthquake in Tokyo, my body reacts to vibrations. Apparently they call it earthquake sickness.”

“Was it bad?”

“What?”

“The earthquake in Tokyo. What else?”

“It felt like the building was going to collapse. It shook hard for about five minutes, but it felt like an hour. And maybe because we were in a high-rise, the movement was much worse. Everyone who was on the trip acted calm at the time, but later they all said they thought they were going to die under the rubble.”

“They say when you’re about to die, something comes to mind, don’t they? Something you regret not doing, someone you want to see, someone you never made peace with…….”

“No. Nothing like that happened to me.”

I take a sip of whisky.

“I woke up thirsty in the company apartment before dawn and went into the kitchen. The refrigerator door was open. The refrigerator itself had crawled about a meter away from the wall. Its power cord was caught on the sink and stretched tight like a dog leash. There had been hundreds of aftershocks all through the night.”

“So what exactly happened in Tokyo?”

“Oh, that. If we’d come home the day after the earthquake, nothing would’ve happened. But because of the business schedule, we couldn’t leave right away. It was the weekend, and because of the earthquake all the flights were sold out. Then the head of PR said we should go out to the nightlife district in Shinjuku on Saturday night.”

“Seriously? In the middle of all that?”

“Hard to believe, isn’t it? Manager Kim from PR said no. He’s the guy who called earlier. Kim’s naturally bold and doesn’t worry much about what his superiors think. Once he said no, I told the head of PR we should just have some beer near the company apartment.”

“And?”

“The head of PR said what did the earthquake in Japan have to do with us? He said when a disaster that big happens, a few tens of thousands of people dying is nothing.”

“Seriously? Is that man insane?”

“I completely lost whatever goodwill I had left toward him. And then the head of PR dragged Kim and me to the nightlife district in Shinjuku anyway. It was one of those places where dancers perform completely naked, with their genitals exposed.”

“That crazy bastard.”

“I felt awful too. Thousands of people had lost their lives in the earthquake, and I couldn’t stand the thought of myself sitting there watching a nude show. So not long after the show started, I walked out. Kim came out a little later.”

“And?”

“When the show ended, the head of PR came out too. Then he started yelling at us for walking out in the middle. He said it was disrespectful to the dancers. Suddenly Kim started swearing at the head of PR, even though the man was more than twenty years older. He said, ‘You’re always bragging that you came out of the student movement. So this is what a fucking democracy fighter amounts to?’ The head of PR got worked up and tried to punch Kim. I barely managed to get between them. It was ugly that night.”

“So Kim got disciplined?”

“No. The head of PR hadn’t exactly behaved well either, so we kept the whole thing among ourselves and let it end there. If word got around, it wouldn’t have been good for him either. We finished the trip and came home. Nothing happened for a while, but then recently the story started going around the company.”

“So it reached the point where it couldn’t just be ignored.”

“Pretty much. It became a mess.”

“So how did it end?”

“Kim handed in his resignation and said he was sick of the whole thing. He’s still single and he’s good at his job, so he’ll find another position easily enough. The problem is the head of PR. Once the rumors started making him look bad, I think he gave the company a different version of what happened.”

“What version?”

“That Kim was the one who wanted to go out in Shinjuku, and he had no choice but to follow.”

“What a joke. That bastard. That fucking bastard.”

“Kim said he might be leaving, but he wasn’t going to leave with that accusation hanging over him. He asked me to be a witness.”

“A witness?”

“He says he’s going to submit a written report about the whole incident before he leaves. I tried telling him that if he was resigning anyway, maybe he should just leave quietly, but he wouldn’t listen. Kim says there’s no way. If he goes down, the head of PR is going down with him. He says he has nothing to lose.”

“Then why did you follow him there in the first place?”

“I’ve got no excuse.”

“Yeah.” Munja let out a long sigh. “The big boss in PR tells you to go—how were you supposed to refuse? It’s not easy. So how did it end?”

“I handed in my resignation yesterday.” I paused for a moment before continuing. “The head of PR formally apologized to Kim and me. He said he hadn’t thought things through. And Kim apologized to me too. Said he was sorry for dragging me into all that trouble. In the end, as things at companies often do, the whole affair just sort of fizzled out in the spirit of leaving well enough alone.”

“But somehow you don’t want to work with them anymore. Is that it?”

“Yeah. No. I don’t know. I don’t particularly blame either of them. It’s just……”

Still, whenever I thought about the earthquake that day and the dancers in Shinjuku, I couldn’t shake the self-disgust that washed over me. The great earthquake had awakened me to the reality of death, and that awakening collapsed within a single day in front of dancers performing with their genitals exposed. Willingly or not, I couldn’t shake the feeling that I had gone too far, using the organization and its hierarchy as an excuse.

“You did the right thing.” Munja took both my hands in hers. “Just let yourself be for a while, until you feel like doing something new. That’s probably best.”

I gave a faint smile and nodded.

“I don’t think Aji is breathing.”

Munja carefully slipped her feet away and stood up from the sofa.

“Give me a hand mirror.”

While Munja went to get one, I gently shook the Chihuahua. It did not move at all. Munja came back and handed me the mirror, looking frightened. I held it under the Chihuahua’s nose. A faint patch of mist formed on the glass.

“I’m glad you’re here tonight. Thank you.”

I looked at the clock on the living-room wall. It was almost ten.

“Could you stay a little longer tonight?”

“Don’t worry. I might stay the night.”

A little after midnight, Munja went into the bedroom and I lay down on the living-room sofa. Perhaps because the apartment was up on a hill, I couldn’t hear cars or delivery motorcycles. I carefully tried saying the name Subin out loud. As I did, I hoped that all the dark, ominous memories of childhood that surfaced when she closed her eyes and slipped a hand beneath her pillow would disappear along with the name Munja.

There was another thud from the ceiling. My body stiffened for a moment. No sound came from the bedroom. I lay on the sofa and stared at the ceiling for a while. Then I quietly closed my eyes. I pictured the face that had come to me first inside that building in Tokyo as it shook as if it were about to collapse. What would Subin think if she knew that, in the moment when I believed I might die, she was

the person I wanted to see most? I will not tell her. I want to keep to myself the moment when the quiet love that had rested deep inside my heart woke up.

A Stolen Afternoon

Until I went to my homeroom teacher for an early-leave slip today, I had a fever, a headache, aches in my pelvis and breasts, swelling all over, and I was irritable for no reason. Strangely, once I got the slip, I began to feel better, and by the time I walked out through the school gate, not a single part of my aching body hurt anymore. The pain disappeared as if Jesus had cured a leper. Even my head felt clear. There must be something wrong with the ground our school is built on. Anyway, I really had been sick earlier. I felt a little guilty thinking of my classmates, who were probably tearing their hair out over the math quiz right about now. Besides, sixth period was physics with Mr. Byun Jae-ho, the Human Sleeping Pill. If I hadn't left early today, I might have had to call 119 for an ambulance. So the teachers should be grateful to me. I had voluntarily gone home early and made this neat little recovery. Now that I felt fine again, I might as well make good use of this golden Friday afternoon.

Across the intersection, Sani waved at me from the other side of the crosswalk. I raised my hand slightly, then lowered it. I didn't wave. What a phony. She'd said only this morning that she didn't want to cut class, yet she'd left before me and was already waiting. Sani had been my best friend since our third year of middle school. If you wanted to find me at school, all you had to know was where Sani was. We even went to the bathroom together. During breaks, we were always together. I

don't know why, but I felt at ease when I was with Sani. I could give hundreds of reasons, but none of them would explain exactly what there was between us. I just liked her.

Except for the fact that we were both only children, Sani and I had nothing in common. I was a handspan taller than she was, though that didn't make me tall. Sani was small and cute, like a little doll, and boys had confessed their feelings to her several times since middle school. I, on the other hand, had never had a confession, or even a friendly look. I lived with two working parents and got a generous allowance, while Sani had been living alone with her grandmother in an old rental apartment since the year before last. Her parents had divorced when she was young, so she had lived for a while with her dad, for a while with her biological mother, for a while with her father's older brother, and for a while with her father's older sister. She had been passed from house to house like a basketball, yet Sani was always bright and cheerful. Of course, I couldn't tell whether that was how she really felt or just an act. I was the kind of person who got gloomy all day if it rained, so what I envied most was Sani's cheerful nature.

There was exactly one person Sani hated: her biological mother. Sani never called her Mom. She always called her biological mother. Maybe that was why the woman seemed less like a mother than some stranger living far away. From what Sani had written in our private <Gray Notebook>, her biological mother was the kind of woman even Jesus would have trouble getting to repent. While Sani was living on sufferance in relatives' homes, her biological mother never contributed a cent toward raising her. On top of that, after Sani's dad died the year before last, his divorced ex-wife swallowed the entire life-insurance payout herself. As his death

drew near, Sani's father's older brother advised him to name Sani's grandmother as the beneficiary. For some reason, Sani's dad ignored the advice. Sani called her own father a complete idiot and was always saying that nobody could beat an idiot. Her biological mother, who saw Sani once every two or three months, seemed to think she'd done her duty as a mother by starting to send a tiny allowance to Sani's account a few months ago.

Sani couldn't afford cram school, but her grades were near the top. She was especially good at math. I, on the other hand, had given up on math early. Life was easier once I gave up. Luckily, I'd seen a news report saying that because the population was shrinking, universities were now having to court students. Somewhere there had to be a university that would take a student like me who'd given up on math, so what was the point of worrying already? First-year high-school grades counted for only twenty percent. And there was still plenty of time before the CSAT. Besides, I was ridiculously lucky. Obviously I couldn't leave everything to luck, but I didn't think there was anything wrong with counting on it a little.

I'd been to Sani's place only once. I'd heard so much about public rental apartments that I'd expected the place to feel a little scary and unsafe, but the complex was surprisingly neat and well kept. Sani's apartment was much smaller than ours, yet it was spotless. It made me wonder whether the shocked look on Sani's face the first time she came to my house had been less about how big our place was than about how messy and dirty it was.

"What excuse did you use? Your teacher gave you the early-leave slip right away?"

Sani asked.

"Period cramps. But once I decided to lie about it, I actually started getting the symptoms. My stomach hurt like crazy, my head was pounding, and my breasts felt like somebody was squeezing them."

I said, linking my arm through Sani's.

"You're a natural. All you have to do is decide, and you can even channel a girl who's having her period."

"Want to go to Hongdae for an iced coffee? It's so hot today. How about Starbucks?"

"I don't like that place."

"Then want to go to our hair salon? I was thinking of getting mine cut before it gets any hotter. By the way, how did you get your early-leave slip?"

"I asked Grandma to text my teacher."

"What did she say?"

"Actually, I have to go to my biological mother's hospital now."

"Why? Is she sick?"

"No. My biological mother hasn't sent me my allowance for three months." Sani's face darkened. "I told Grandma I was going to confront her about taking all of Dad's insurance money and then not even giving me my allowance, so Grandma texted my homeroom teacher. I don't know what she wrote, but my teacher got worried and told me to hurry home. My grandma's hilarious, isn't she?"

"You didn't write anything in the Gray Notebook about your allowance being late. I thought it was supposed to be our secret notebook."

I felt bad for talking about Starbucks and the hair salon without knowing what was going on with Sani, but I was also a little hurt that she'd kept something from me.

"I was too embarrassed to tell you. Sorry." Sani said, tickling me at the waist. "Anyway, I'm going to my biological mother's hospital today and raising hell. That money isn't all hers. Dad meant some of it for me, so why does she get to swallow the whole thing? Having to beg for my allowance every month is so humiliating I could die."

We took the subway and then a bus to the hospital where Sani's biological mother worked. A lot of foreign workers were hospitalized there, and the hospital was especially well known for microsurgery to reattach severed fingers. Sani's biological mother was the head nurse on an inpatient ward. If marriage and childbirth hadn't interrupted her career, she would probably be a head nurse at a big hospital downtown by now, but life hadn't worked out that way. The large clock in the ward lobby read 2:45.

"Good." Sani let out a sigh of relief. "She's the head nurse on the ward, so she starts at seven and gets off at three."

"Want me to go to the nurses' station with you?"

"No. I'll wait in the lobby and make a scene in front of all the patients."

We waited for Sani's biological mother in the hospital lobby. It felt as if every sick worker in the world had gathered there. Thai, Vietnamese, Indian, and Filipino patients spoke among themselves in their own languages, then switched easily into Korean when someone from another country spoke to them. It was a striking contrast to a European dancer I'd once heard about who said that after more than

ten years in Seoul, she'd never once felt any need to learn Korean. Every patient seemed to have a hand or arm wrapped in bandages. I tried not to let it get to me, but looking around, I couldn't help feeling gloomy.

Sani's biological mother came down to the lobby at exactly 3:05. Sani strode toward her, waving both arms hard. Startled, her mother could only stammer, "You... why are you here?" She looked like a woman who'd just had some enormous secret exposed. So she'd been pretending to be single. Busted, I thought. Sure enough, Sani's biological mother grabbed her by the wrist and tried to drag her out of the building. Sani struggled and shouted, "Give me my money!" and in the next instant her mother had hauled her away. I slung Sani's bag over my shoulder and ran after them. In front of the ward parking lot, Sani was screaming at her biological mother. I ran over and planted myself behind Sani, hands on my hips, trying to look bold and supportive. Her biological mother took her phone from her handbag, transferred the three months of overdue allowance plus three months in advance into Sani's account, then shoved the confirmation screen under Sani's nose. "There. Happy?" As she walked farther into the parking lot, she muttered, "Everything you do is exactly like your father."

Tears ran down Sani's cheeks. I took her hand and led her to a bench in the shade of a cherry tree. She cried hard for a while, then spat sharply on the ground and stood up.

"Let's go." There were still tears in Sani's eyes, but her voice was strong. "I'll buy you something good."

Something tightened in my chest. The amount on the transfer screen Sani's biological mother had shown her was less than two months of my allowance. If I

counted what my parents spent on private tutoring, half a year of Sani's allowance wasn't even close to what I spent in a month.

"Then I want the best tteokbokki in the world."

I said it with an exaggeratedly happy face.

The trip from Sani's biological mother's hospital to Hongdae was long and brutal. We waited forever for the bus to the subway station, and sure enough, when it finally came, it was packed. One passenger complained about how late it was, and the driver explained that the bus ahead had been in a minor accident. The passenger then demanded to know how the bus could still be this late, which made no sense at all. Why blame the driver of the bus behind for an accident involving the one in front? Once we got moving, the same passenger started complaining that the air-conditioning was too weak. He grumbled as if picking fights were his whole purpose in life and managed to make everyone else uncomfortable too. The subway was every bit as crowded. My legs were trembling and I wanted to sit in one of the seats reserved for pregnant women, but there was no way I could do that in my school uniform. What if my picture ended up all over the internet the next day under the headline PREGNANT HIGH-SCHOOL GIRL? These days it was easier to have strangers dig up your identity, strip your life bare, and send everything straight to hell than it was to cut class. Anyway, Friday afternoon on the bus and subway was far too horrible a price for skipping fifth-period math and sixth-period physics.

On the subway to Hongdae, I was about to KakaoTalk Mom and tell her I'd eat with Sani before coming home when a message from her arrived first.

"Sweetie, Mom's going to be a little late today."

I answered in a slightly sulky tone.

"Why? Am I eating alone again? Dad said he can't come home this week either."

Dad had been transferred to Naju Innovation City the previous fall, so he came home only every other Friday. Then he spent the whole weekend saying how tired he was, and on Sunday afternoon he took the company bus back to Naju. Dad said that even when the bus was free, riding it for more than four hours was exhausting. I asked why he couldn't take the KTX. He said the train cost a hundred thousand won round trip and taxis were another forty thousand. Two trips home a month would cost 280,000 won, and four would cost 560,000. So I suggested he come home twice a month by KTX and taxi and give me half of the transportation money as extra allowance. Dad said in that case maybe the whole family should just move to Naju Innovation City. That was the end of that. I missed him when he wasn't home, but there was one advantage: I only had to watch Mom and Dad fight twice a month.

"You still have the card Mom gave you, right?"

"Yeah."

"Invite Sani too. Order whatever you want."

"Okay."

"Sweetie, let's go shopping this weekend. I'll buy you some summer clothes."

The words summer clothes suddenly gave me a brilliant idea.

"Mom, listen..."

"What? Did my girl suddenly think of something she wants to do?"

"No."

"Tell me."

"Can Sani and I buy a pair of shorts and a short-sleeved top each at Abbey Road today?"

The little "1" beside my message disappeared, but Mom didn't answer. I got a little nervous, though conversations often stopped in the middle because of her work, so I waited. About twenty minutes later, her reply came.

"Sure. Just one outfit each at Abbey Road. Mom will buy you something nicer tomorrow. Love you, sweetie."

I answered "love you" by dropping an avalanche of emojis on her.

"Yes! Mom says she's going to be late today."

I said it with a grin. I hadn't mentioned the summer clothes yet. "Let's hang around Hongdae and then go to my house. Mom says you can come over and we can order anything we want. What do you think?"

Sani gave a little laugh.

"Sounds good."

While Sani texted her grandmother, I started planning the rest of our day in my head.

As soon as we get to Hongdae, we'll go straight to Abbey Road and buy cool T-shirts and shorts. Stuff these gloomy uniforms into our bags and transform ourselves. Then we'll get Yeopgi Tteokbokki. We'll order Set A, with dumplings, vegetable fritters, and fried seaweed rolls. The Original is way too spicy, so we'll get Mild. Then Sani can eat it too. Sani acts tough, but she's actually soft inside and can't handle spicy food. We should order a separate bowl of fish cakes too. That'll put us over twenty thousand won. What should I do? Right, I'll tell her Mom is paying. If Sani says no, I have to respect her pride, so I'll ask her to buy me a Ryan

pen at the Kakao Friends Store. That won't be too much for her. A sweet coffee at Starbucks would be healing, but I don't know why Sani hates the place so much. Maybe it's because the coffee is too expensive? Then I'll tell her we're using Mom's money and try to talk her into it one more time.

When we came out of the subway station, the streets of Hongdae were packed too. People, bicycles, motorcycles, cars, and buses tangled together in the narrow alleys until the whole place looked like chaos. I liked crowded, dirty Hongdae better than our quiet neighborhood.

"If I'd known it would be like this, I would've brought some regular clothes." I slipped the subject in casually. "Our uniforms really stand out, don't they?"

"Then want to buy something for summer at Abbey Road and change?"

"Hey, are you psychic?"

"Psychic?"

"I was KakaoTalking with Mom earlier and got permission to buy summer clothes at Abbey Road. Let's get an outfit each. My mom's buying."

"Really? But still..."

Before Sani could refuse, I linked arms with her and put on a nasal, whiny voice. "We don't have to buy anything expensive. We'll get something cheap. One outfit each, as a souvenir from our expedition to Incheon."

"Garam, you're really kind."

"Sani, don't cry."

"Do you know why I call my dad a complete idiot?"

"Because your biological mother took the insurance money?"

"That too. But because of something he said when he was dying."

"What?"

"He said everybody has a Buddha or Jesus inside their heart, and an evil spirit too. When you meet someone, you're supposed to make a relationship with the good part of them. But then he said he'd spent his whole life using his own evil spirit to meet everyone else's evil spirit, so he'd lived in hell. Don't you think it's stupid for a grown man to figure that out only when he's dying? You're only seventeen and you already know all that. My dad really was a complete idiot."

I didn't answer. I just squeezed her arm tighter against mine. With her tears gone, Sani and I marched toward Abbey Road. It wasn't even sale season, but the store was so crowded there was barely room to stand. Sani chose a short-sleeved checked shirt and yellow shorts, and somehow the already cute little thing looked even cuter. Walking around Hongdae dressed like that, she was going to have college guys lining up for her phone number. I chose a white crew-neck shirt and orange shorts. We stuffed our uniforms into our bags and stepped out of Abbey Road in our regular clothes.

I kept worrying that the crew neck made my neck look ridiculously long, but Sani said it was fine, so I decided to stop thinking about it. On the way to get tteokbokki, two college guys asked Sani for her number. Probably because of the crew-neck shirt, nobody asked for mine. I told Sani she ought to save herself the trouble and make a name tag with her phone number on it and wear it on her chest. She said that was a fantastic idea and promised she would definitely do it once she was in college. She smiled brightly. Before I knew it, her smile had spread to my face too. Laughing together, we roamed the streets of Hongdae.

* * *

For the past several days, Garam had been filling the <Gray Notebook> with every kind of wheedling she could come up with, begging me to cut Friday afternoon classes and go hang out in Hongdae. Garam was ruled by the weather. No depressing rain, no gloomy wind, warm sunlight pouring down—and immediately her heart started fluttering and she wanted to go somewhere. Fine dust and yellow dust had been so bad that spring that even the early heat felt like a blessing. Garam never got time to herself on weekends because of her parents. Her dad, who came home once every two weeks, carried Garam around as if she belonged in his pocket, while her mom, an executive at an advertising agency, packed all the mothering she couldn't do during the week into Saturday and Sunday. Lucky bitch. Fifth period was math, my favorite subject, but sixth period was physics and, seriously, forget it. A few days earlier, Mr. Byun Jae-ho had cited some survey saying fifty-six percent of high-school students would be willing to commit a crime and go to prison if they could get a billion won out of it, then lectured us forever as if we were all criminals in training. I couldn't stand people who believed the world would stop turning if they ever quit nagging. Why did adults even conduct garbage surveys like that? Instead of setting an example by showing us that selling your conscience for a billion won was wrong, they seemed to be sneering, See? You kids are no better than anyone else. People who thought getting older automatically made them adults were the worst. Age was something

time handed you for free. Treating it like a medal earned on a battlefield was ridiculous.

Fine. I would cut afternoon classes. Not that it was only because of Garam. The truth was, my biological mother hadn't sent my allowance for three months. She wouldn't answer my calls or reply to my texts. I had survived this week by raiding the jar of coins in my drawer, but by next week I would be completely broke. It was filthy and humiliating, but I had no choice except to go find my biological mother and demand the money. You could only live off Garam so many times before your soul started evaporating. Why hadn't my idiot father listened to my uncle and changed the insurance beneficiary to Grandma? My biological mother had enough of a conscience to promise my uncle that she would personally take care of my allowance, but promises were all they ever were. She had never once sent it on time. She paid only after I called or texted to ask. Was there any excuse more convenient than I've been busy?

Maybe I should get a part-time job? No. Absolutely not. I wasn't throwing away blood-red chunks of my life for a few coins of spending money. I was going to college. A good college. Going all in on the CSAT suited both our finances and my personality better than trying to win through school records and holistic admissions. I would rather die than smile sweetly and suck up to people. Two and a half more years. That was all I had to endure. I would get into college on a full scholarship and go my own way where everyone could see me. Imagine my uncle, his wife, and my older female cousin's faces when I showed them my acceptance letter. My cousin always acted friendly in front of the adults and did every rotten

thing she could think of behind their backs. In the end I couldn't stand her anymore, so I left my uncle's house and moved in with Grandma.

My older female cousin had started college that year, at one of those universities whose name I could hear five times and still forget. I couldn't understand why anybody would bother going to a school that would probably shut down in a few years because it couldn't find enough freshmen. If I got into the university I had my eye on, the whole family would probably collapse from strokes. I absolutely could not tell my father's older sister, who wore XXL. She might really have another one. She'd had a minor stroke two years earlier, after my gamer cousin blew several million won on game items and then lost more than ten million won gambling online. How much money even was ten million won?

My two cousins were so evenly matched in stupidity that ranking them was almost impossible, but the girl was slightly stupider. At least the boy knew he was an idiot. She didn't even know that. The two of them hated each other so much that whenever they met, they tore each other to pieces. Sadly, out of all the nonsense they said, the things they said about each other were the only truths.

Once I decided to cut afternoon classes, I got my early-leave slip and waited for Garam at the intersection in front of school. About ten minutes later I saw her and waved my arm high in the air. Garam merely lifted her hand a few inches and lowered it again. Such a phony. Then she came over and wrapped her arm tightly around mine, which was cute. The second she saw me, she started chattering excitedly about Starbucks in Hongdae and going to a hair salon. Garam knew what my situation was, so she always paid for me too. It wasn't that I particularly envied those Starbucks planners she collected every year, but someday I wanted to own

one of those things myself and say to her, Here. You take this. Still, no planner in the world mattered to me as much as the <Gray Notebook>. I wrote maybe eighty-seven percent of the truth in it. Without that notebook, I might have gone crazy. Garam and I had started writing one line at a time in the autumn of our third year of middle school, and now there wasn't a blank page left. Garam was always accusing me of hiding too much from the <Gray Notebook>, but she did exactly the same thing. Last summer, in the parking lot, Garam's mom... No. I'm not telling that. I had no intention of blabbing about something Garam herself had chosen not to write in the notebook. Anyway, Garam probably wrote about eighty-seven percent of the truth too. Maybe it was better not to reveal the rest. If my idiot father and my biological mother had taught me anything, it was that nothing was more terrifying than the whole truth. Maybe people were able to keep a comfortable distance from one another because of a reasonable amount of pretending. Without pretending, there would be no saving face. And without that, the space between people would become a vacuum, with nothing to slow down the hurt as it traveled from one person to another. Maybe Garam and I could stand straight beside each other without casting shadows over one another because of that thirteen percent of empty space between us. I was a little surprised when Garam insisted on following me all the way to the hospital in Incheon where my biological mother worked. At first I told her I would go alone and that she could wait for me at Starbucks in Hongdae. Garam sulked so badly that there was no way I could leave her behind. So we changed from subway to bus and set off on our expedition to distant Incheon. It had been almost six months since I had last seen my biological mother. She disliked me because she said I looked like Dad. I disliked her right back. Her

reason for disliking me was flimsy. Mine was perfectly decent and justified. Only an idiot treated people well when they hated you. In the hospital, when Dad was dying, he had talked about good hearts and evil spirits as though he had suddenly become Buddha or Jesus, but he had missed everything that actually mattered. I had lived for a while with Dad, for a while with my biological mother, for a while with my uncle, for a while with my aunt, and now for a while with Grandma. If all that had taught me one thing, it was the absolute and unchanging truth that you treat people the way they treat you. I would make a scene, get my allowance, and walk away without looking back. And I would not cry.

On the crowded subway, Garam put in her earbuds and listened to music. I wished she would study a little harder. Sure, only twenty percent of our first-year grades counted, but sometimes Garam seemed less like a first-year high-school student than a fourth-year middle-school student. She was so relaxed that I wondered whether she knew people said your ranking on the first practice exam of high school tended to follow you all the way to the CSAT. If we wanted to stay close after high school, it would be better if we got into universities that were somewhere near the same level. Still, Garam was my favorite person in the world. She was nothing like me. I was dry and brittle, like a pile of old hay. They said the human body was mostly water, but my body and mind had been suffering through a drought for years. I didn't even want to imagine what I would have become if I hadn't met someone like Garam, who was more like a river.

It took an hour and a half to reach the hospital where my biological mother worked. She was head nurse on an inpatient ward now, but she'd worked in outpatient care before. Before she got married, people said she had been famous for

being good in the "surgery room." She always called the operating room the surgery room. She had first met Dad at the hospital when he was admitted after a minor traffic accident. Even now, whenever she thought about it, she got furious and kept saying, "I must've been a crazy bitch to fall in love with a fake patient." Dad had died at forty-three. According to the relatives, he was incompetent and had more than a little con man in him. Apparently he'd even gone through quite a lot of money from my biological mother's family.

According to my uncle's wife, who was about as rational and neutral as anyone in our family got, I shouldn't curse my biological mother too much for taking Dad's life-insurance money. Maybe Dad had wanted the payout to settle what he owed her. When I lived with my uncle's family, his wife had asked me to call her Mom, and I hadn't particularly minded. She really had tried hard to act like one, and because of her I had managed not to go off the rails. Sometimes I preferred their house, with at least the atmosphere of a proper family, to Grandma's, where absolutely everything belonged in another century. My uncle's wife was my last emergency exit. When I truly had nowhere else to turn, I called her. She never asked why. She just sent me the money I needed. It was never much, but exactly three times in my life I had received secret emergency money from her.

At 3:05, my biological mother came down to the lobby. I took one deep breath and charged toward her, but my heart was pounding so hard that no words came out. She seemed startled too. She stammered and tried to lead me outside. I fought against her and yelled, "Give me my money!" She dragged me out of the building in seconds. I screamed with everything I had for her to give me my money. At that moment, I couldn't see anything else. I had reached the point where there was

nothing left to lose. I knew Garam was beside me, but I wasn't ashamed. She had seen me in worse states than this plenty of times. And yet I hadn't become a bad kid. I hadn't turned into someone who blamed everybody else because of what had happened to me. If anything, I hated being pitied, so I made sure nobody noticed anything. Teachers spent all their time on the troublemakers and paid no attention to ordinary kids. I wanted to be an ordinary kid who needed no attention, and I had worked harder than anyone to become one. But right then, I felt that if I didn't let everything explode, I would be a loser forever. I was only seventeen, but I knew better than anyone that when you swallow anger at the moment you ought to be angry, you pay several times the price later.

My biological mother dragged me as far as the parking lot, pulled out her phone, and sent me six months' allowance, including everything she owed me. I had won. I didn't cry. Then she walked deeper into the parking lot and said, "Everything you do is exactly like your father." The tears came anyway. I clenched my fists and fought desperately not to make a sound. Then Garam took my hand, and I couldn't hold it in anymore. After I cried it out, instead of feeling drained, I felt a fighting spirit for life rise through my whole body. I wiped my tears and promised myself that even when hopeless things happened, even when nothing went the way I wanted, I would never sink into self-pity. I spat hard on the ground with all my strength and got up from the bench.

On the bus and subway to Hongdae, Garam kept grinning at her phone as though something wonderful had happened. We had waited more than twenty minutes for the bus under the blazing sun, and the subway was packed, but she never showed the slightest sign that she was tired. It actually made me feel guilty.

When Garam happily announced that her mom had given her permission to spend the evening with me, I decided that for today, I would just let Garam have whatever she wanted.

Garam will say it's been ages since she came to Hongdae and want to go buy clothes at Abbey Road. This time I'll beat her to it. Last year's summer clothes are too small anyway, so I need something new. At Yeopgi Tteokbokki, I'll order the Original today instead of Mild, because that's what Garam likes. It's pretty spicy, but if I scrape off some of the sauce, I can handle it. I already said I would buy the tteokbokki, but Garam will obviously use her mom as an excuse and try to pay. Fine. I'll let her. Then at the Kakao Friends Store, I'll buy us our second <Gray Notebook> as a present. I bet even Garam hasn't thought of that. And I'll do that Starbucks healing thing she loves so much with her too.

I sat there thinking about all this, feeling ridiculously happy, and before I knew it we had reached Hongdae Station. Exactly as I expected, the moment we came out of the station, Garam casually brought up regular clothes. Following my plan, I got there first and suggested we go to Abbey Road for summer clothes. Then Garam said she had already gotten permission from her mom and wanted to buy mine too. My nose stung and tears sprang into my eyes. Garam linked arms with me and called it a souvenir from our expedition to Incheon, even finding a way to protect my pride. Suddenly I thought of my idiot father and told her his stupid philosophy about the Buddha or Jesus inside people, and the evil spirit inside them too. Garam said nothing. She only squeezed my arm tighter. That was the signal she gave when she agreed with me completely.

Dressed in the great new summer clothes we'd bought at Abbey Road, Garam and I marched through Hongdae to attack the tteokbokki place. It was Friday afternoon and the streets were a sea of people. Everyone pushed forward and backward, bumping shoulders.

"Garam, your shoelace is undone."

I crouched down and tied her shoelace.

"Garam, your period..."

Before I could finish, Garam shouted.

"Wow! Thank God."

All day, we'd both felt a little guilty about cutting class with a fake period as our excuse. At last, we could hold our heads up again. Well, not that high...